A HISTORICAL NOVEL

The Price of Marble

CHAPTERS 1–8 OF 25

INCOMPLETE MANUSCRIPT

MATURE / 18+

Reader’s note

This is an incomplete manuscript containing Chapters 1–8 of a planned 25-chapter novel. It is not the complete book.

Intended for mature readers aged eighteen and over. Adult themes and disturbing material.

This is a work of fiction. Its principal characters and their private histories are invented. Historical settings have been used imaginatively.

This reading edition contains the manuscript only. Planning notes, future chapter titles and plot summaries have been omitted.

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CHAPTER ONE

The Measure of a House

The fish arrived alive, which was something Antonia had specifically refused to pay for.

They thrashed in a shallow tub outside her kitchen while the fishmonger's boy argued that their freshness was a gift. Water struck the paving stones. One of the mullet had rubbed a red patch through its silver scales, and the boy kept turning the tub so that she would not see it. He was perhaps sixteen, with a man's hands and a child's willingness to repeat an absurdity until someone else became tired.

"Your master thinks I own a pond," she said.

"He said you liked to see what you were getting."

"Then why is that one always facing away from me?"

The boy looked down. In the doorway behind her, the cook made an impatient noise through his nose. The bread ovens had been lit before dawn; now the kitchen needed its water carriers, and the tub occupied the only clear passage between the cistern and the hearths.

Antonia crouched. Her knees resented it. She put two fingers into the water, touched the damaged fish, and watched it slide beneath the others.

"Take that one home. We will pay the agreed price for the rest. Tell him I am not paying for the boy who ran with the water, either."

"That was me."

"Then you may complain to yourself on the way back."

He smiled before remembering his master's instructions. The cook lifted the tub with both arms and disappeared into

the kitchen. Somewhere inside, a woman shouted for the fish to be kept away from her pastry. Antonia stood, brushing a wet mark from her wrist.

She liked this hour, though she could seldom have explained why. Before the lamps, the perfume and the guests, the house confessed what it required. Ash to be taken out. Flour. Fresh water. Someone to stand with an aching shoulder and stir a pot. In the garden, two women were shaking the night insects from the rose branches, and the freedman who tended her lamps was scraping yesterday's black residue out of the spouts. Nothing yet pretended to happen by itself.

Damaris waited beneath the little shrine beside the passage. She had the household tablets pressed against her hip, a bunch of keys suspended from a cord, and a scrap of pale wool on one sleeve. Antonia picked it off.

"Were you mending before breakfast?"

"Felix put his knee through the good tunic."

"Again?"

"He says it was the other knee."

"A useful distinction."

The steward did not smile. She opened the top tablet and held it where the light reached the wax.

There were to be twelve guests that evening, though one senator invariably brought a man whose name he had forgotten to mention. Severus had asked for the room overlooking the garden. Varro had sent ahead to ask whether Nysa would be present. Two musicians needed paying for a postponed engagement. The supplier of charcoal wanted his money before the next delivery, having accepted too many promises from another household farther up the hill.

Antonia listened, looking through the open doorway at the tree in the centre of the court. Its first figs were small and hard. A cracked branch had been bound with strips of linen, a repair the gardener insisted would hold.

"Pay the musicians. Pay the charcoal man half and promise the rest in six days. No, give him two thirds. He must be tired of hearing promises. Varro can ask Nysa himself."

"He offered more."

"For her, or for us?"

"He did not distinguish."

"Then distinguish for him."

Damaris made a mark. Her writing was small and crowded; as a girl she had learnt to make a single tablet serve where her teacher would have used three. Antonia had offered her larger ones. She always returned to these.

From beyond the wall came the rumble of an empty cart leaving the city before the streets were closed to most daytime traffic. A mule objected to something. The sound continued long after the cart had passed.

"There is the other matter," Damaris said.

Antonia glanced at the keys.

"I have not forgotten."

"I did not say you had."

They stood with the cool of the night still gathered in the passage. It would have been easy to turn towards the kitchen, to call for a disputed basket of vegetables, and Antonia was irritated by how obvious the possibility had become to both of them.

"How much now?"

"Eight thousand, four hundred and sixty sestertii. With what you said you would put against it."

"And without?"

"Six thousand, four hundred and sixty."

Damaris had not consulted her tablet. Antonia knew what the money represented: gifts from guests at the New Year, allowances retained from marketing, small payments for writing letters for servants who could not write their own. Some of it Antonia had given her, which made the exactness

feel ungrateful. The feeling was ugly. She let it pass before she spoke.

"We must have Crispus go through the legal arrangements. There are restrictions where a child is concerned. You know that."

"I know Felix cannot simply come because I do."

"I would not separate you."

"Then put it in the arrangement."

Antonia moved the tablet a little farther into the light, though she had no need to read it.

They had first discussed freedom in the winter. Antonia had been lying under blankets with a fever, and Damaris had sat through two nights changing the cloth against her neck. In the helplessness of recovery, Antonia had said that they should settle things before another year was lost. At the time she had meant it. She meant it now. What she had failed to mean was that Damaris might remember the words as a promise with a date attached.

"If you leave," Antonia said, "I will need to train someone."

"I have not said I will leave."

"But you could."

Damaris closed the tablet. The click was quiet.

"Yes."

Antonia looked at her then. Thirty-two, with the first grey near her left temple. Damaris had come to the house carrying a baby she would let no one hold. Now that baby could climb the garden wall, find a falling tile before the roof man did, and eat three portions of anything that was meant for somebody else. Antonia had been generous to them. She had also been their owner for almost eleven years.

"After tonight," she said. "Tomorrow I will speak to Crispus. You may hear me do it."

"Thank you."

There was no warmth in the gratitude, and Antonia found herself wishing for the old easy manner before she remembered what had purchased it.

A kitchen girl hurried past with a basket of greens. Damaris stepped aside, and the household began moving around them again.

Crispus was in the narrow room where Antonia kept the business accounts, wearing a woollen cap although the morning was no longer cold. He had used a heavy bronze lamp to weigh down an unrolled sheet of papyrus. At his elbow lay a piece of bread which appeared to have been spread with nothing at all.

"You will choke," Antonia said.

"Not at the price of oil."

She broke the bread, dipped half into the bowl he had hidden behind the lamp, and ate it. The oil tasted of pepper. He had been to the market himself.

"Damaris will tell you something tomorrow," she said. "We need proper advice about freeing her and the boy together."

He adjusted the edge of the papyrus.

"At last?"

"Do not make me regret telling you before she does."

"That would be difficult. She told me in February."

Antonia looked at him. Crispus had been her fellow slave once, and later the keeper of their patron's estate. Age had made him less deferential, but not braver; he merely chose his dangers with more precision.

"You might have mentioned it."

"She asked what would be needed. I answered. It was not mine to mention."

On the sheet beneath his hand were the accounts for the river warehouses in which Antonia held a share. Most years they were the least troublesome part of her fortune. Men with grain required dry rooms. The rooms existed whether she

entertained senators or offended them. Rent came in, repairs were paid, and Crispus made small, satisfied marks.

Today the marks crowded one side of the page.

"Ostia again?"

"The west roofs. There is another estimate."

"Another?"

"Timber costs more than when they first asked. So does a man who will work above ground."

"They were to repair those roofs last autumn."

"They were to be paid last autumn. We retained the distribution instead."

She remembered the decision. A bath furnace had failed here; a vineyard payment had come late; the warehouse manager had said that the roofs would serve one more winter. He had put it in writing, and she had liked him for giving her something she could file.

"Was there damage?"

"Not that he admits."

She took the page. Among the names of contractors and guarantors, Fabius Severus appeared twice. His money seemed to have a habit of arriving before anyone had sent for it.

"He is dining here tonight," she said.

"Then offer him the fish. He has already swallowed the roof."

"What does that mean?"

Crispus rubbed the side of his nose.

"It means I want the partnership book from Ostia, not another polite letter saying the partnership book is being brought up to date."

Antonia set the page down carefully.

From the court came a crash, followed by the unmistakable silence of a child deciding whether he had been heard. Damaris called her son's name. Crispus reached for the remaining bread, missed it, and looked accusingly at Antonia.

"Have the manager bring the book," she said. "Send someone today. And give Damaris whatever she needs to begin."

He nodded, once for each instruction. Neither felt finished when she left him.

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By the time the first guests arrived, the kitchen passage had been scrubbed, the dead fish had acquired a sauce, and a hundred small preparations had been made to resemble ease.

Antonia stood near the fountain in a deep green gown with a gold pin at her shoulder. A freedwoman could own emeralds; whether she ought to wear them depended on who was looking. Tonight she wore two, small enough to oblige a man to come nearer if he wished to assess them.

Severus assessed them from a distance. He was a broad man, pleasantly heavy without appearing slow, and he stopped to greet the door porter by name. The porter had once belonged to his brother. Severus remembered this when it was useful to suggest affection.

"You have changed the lamps," he said.

"Only the oil."

"Then I congratulate the olives."

He gave her a folded letter, sealed but not tied.

"A recommendation for your acquaintance at the marble yard. My nephew intends to build something too large. I told him you could save him from the worst men."

"Does he want saving?"

"He wants a portico. The distinction will occur to him later."

There were favours which arrived disguised as gifts, and requests which brought their own payment. Antonia accepted the letter. She would send it to the marble merchant; he would remember the introduction when she next needed a

length of coloured stone or a discreet loan. Severus could have made it himself. That he had not meant he wished her to know he was treating her as useful.

Behind him came two senators, a young advocate with an angry shaving cut, and a merchant from Puteoli who had brought his brother rather than the freedman he had named. Antonia greeted the brother as though he had been expected. Damaris signalled to the serving staff. A place was found.

Varro arrived late, wearing a ring too large for his finger. Nysa was beside the garden doorway, talking to the flute player about his daughter. She had chosen a saffron-coloured dress and pinned her hair without the false curls that Varro had once praised. Antonia noticed the omission and wondered whether he would.

He did.

"No tower tonight?"

"The builder is resting," Nysa said.

He laughed, pleased to be given an answer he could carry into the dining room. When he offered his arm she took it, but not until she had finished what she was saying to the musician.

The diners reclined. Water moved over their fingers. Someone complained that a boy had made the towel too wet; someone else admired the cloth. The first dishes were eggs with a sharp sauce, olives split and dressed with herbs, little pieces of cheese baked in pastry. Antonia had learnt long ago that hungry men mistook the failure of their stomachs for an insult. She kept the beginnings of dinner familiar.

Nysa sat with Varro and the merchant's brother. Across from them Sabina, who was twenty-four and still impressed by titles, listened too earnestly while the advocate explained a case he had not yet won. Thaleia waited near the musicians, testing the tightness of a string. Antonia caught her eye and tipped her chin. The song began before the advocate could give his second account of the same speech.

When the mullet appeared, the senator nearest Antonia asked whether they had been alive in the morning.

"Very," she said.

"You should have brought them in alive. My nephew has a table with a channel through it. He lets them swim past the guests."

"Does he feed them first?"

"I have no idea."

"Then perhaps they are admiring the guests in return."

He gave the careful chuckle of a man deciding whether the joke diminished his nephew. It did, but not sufficiently to require an objection. Antonia turned towards Severus before he could decide otherwise.

The talk travelled from fish to the price of lampreys, from lampreys to an extravagant funeral feast, and thence to the impossibility of keeping sons within an allowance. The merchant's brother said his own son had no allowance and would not know what to do with one. No one answered. He drank and tried to laugh at himself.

Antonia asked about the voyage from Puteoli. Given something he knew, the man became interesting. He had seen a ship unloaded after a storm, the cargo wet but the owner's claim quite dry. Severus asked two questions. The merchant himself began to look less embarrassed by his brother.

At the far couch, Varro put a piece of fish into Nysa's mouth with his fingers. She accepted it, wiped sauce from her lip, and said something that made the men beside her laugh. Her work was not merely being beautiful. Antonia had seen her rescue a dinner from a quarrel over Greek verbs and make a provincial governor believe he had told a story well. Tonight she was doing it with a man who wanted every silence to announce him.

As the dishes changed, Severus leaned nearer.

"You have rooms at Ostia, I believe. In the Sulpician partnership."

"A share of them."

"One should look at these things oneself occasionally. Men grow comfortable when their employers are far away."

"Have mine grown comfortable?"

He peeled a fig with the point of a knife. The fruit had been preserved from another season and had lost its shape.

"I have advanced money for certain expenses. Temporary, of course. Your accountant will have the details."

"He has estimates. He would like details."

"I shall make sure you receive them."

Antonia waited. It was not her habit to rescue a man from his own pause.

"There may be an opportunity," Severus went on, "to simplify the ownership. Too many interests make necessary decisions difficult. You understand. A roof waits while four people find their seals."

"Does it? I was told the roof was waiting for timber."

"That as well."

From the other end of the room came a burst of laughter and then the small hard sound of a cup striking a plate. Nysa had risen. Varro still held her wrist.

Antonia could see the whole room without appearing to look. It was a skill her guests occasionally praised, as though she had acquired it from pleasure rather than necessity. The senator beside her continued describing his nephew's table. She laid a hand on the edge of his couch.

"Forgive me."

Nysa was saying, "That was not what I agreed."

"I said you would be paid."

"And I said no. Let go."

Varro's face had gone pink about the ears. He looked towards the others, inviting the little smile that would make her refusal part of the entertainment. The merchant's brother supplied it before understanding that no one else had.

Antonia arrived beside them.

"Quintus. You are preventing her from bringing you another cup."

"I have a cup."

"Then you are preventing her from leaving."

Nysa pulled her wrist once. Varro released it with a shove, and when she spoke under her breath he struck her across the mouth.

The flute player stopped with a breath still in his cheeks.

For a moment Antonia heard the fountain through the open door. Nysa stood absolutely still. A dark line appeared at the corner of her lip. Varro looked at his own hand, surprised by how much everyone else had noticed it.

Antonia moved between them.

"Damaris. Take Nysa to my room."

"Do not make a performance of it," Varro said.

Antonia did not answer until Nysa was beyond his reach. The woman did not want to go; Antonia could see it in the way she held her shoulders. But she went with Damaris, and the servant carrying the next dish turned so quickly that sauce slid onto his thumb.

"Your cloak will be brought," Antonia said.

"I have not finished dinner."

"You have."

The advocate looked at his plate. One of the senators coughed, a sound which might have become a word had someone offered him a safe one.

Varro stood. He was taller than Antonia, and suddenly young in his furious expectation of being forgiven.

"You know perfectly well what she is."

"I know what room you are in."

"You will regret this."

She had been listening for years to men who considered regret a possession they could bestow. Sometimes they were right. She kept her eyes on the centre of his face.

"Your cloak," she repeated.

The porter had appeared in the doorway with another man behind him. Neither carried a weapon. Antonia would not have the evening remembered as a brawl unless Varro chose to make it one.

He looked at Severus. Severus set down the knife with which he had been peeling the fig.

"Go home, Quintus. The wine has disagreed with you."

It was an escape offered as an explanation. Varro took it badly but took it. At the threshold he stopped to say that he would expect an account of the money already paid.

"You will receive one," Antonia said.

His footsteps passed into the hall. The door closed with a force that made Thaleia look down at her instrument.

Antonia turned back to the room. Her pulse was painfully distinct in her wrists. She asked the cook's boy to remove the spilled sauce, then told the musicians to play something without words.

No one resumed eating immediately. They were waiting for her to tell them what sort of people they had been while they watched.

"The next dish is pork," she said. "I am told it has suffered from waiting for us."

The merchant's brother laughed too loudly. A senator asked for wine. The advocate began speaking to Sabina in a voice softened by the conviction that gentleness cost him nothing. Conversation returned, not to its former ease but to the imitation of ease upon which an evening could be carried to its end.

Severus watched Antonia sit.

"Unfortunate," he said quietly.

"For whom?"

"That depends upon how long you wish it remembered."

She unfolded her napkin. A drop of sauce had darkened the linen near her hand.

"You were speaking about my warehouses."

"Another evening, perhaps."

For the first time she considered that he might have chosen the evening precisely because it could be made difficult to speak of warehouses. She disliked the thought. It came too easily, and easy suspicion could make a fool of her as readily as trust.

She smiled at the senator who was asking for the name of the singer. She supplied Thaleia's name. Behind the music, the servants continued bringing in the food.

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Nysa held a cloth to her mouth while Crispus counted silver onto the table. She had washed her face. The saffron dress lay over the back of a chair, a small bloodstain stiffening near the shoulder where she had touched it without thinking.

"It is not necessary to count so slowly," she told him.

"It is necessary to count correctly."

"Both might be possible."

Antonia stayed in the doorway until he finished. A brazier had been brought up from the kitchen, and the room smelt of warm metal and crushed herbs. Damaris was not there. Somewhere farther along the passage her son was objecting sleepily to being washed.

"That is the fee for tonight," Crispus said. "And what Varro owed from before."

"Did he pay it?"

"You are being paid."

"That was not what I asked."

Antonia crossed the room.

"No. He did not. We will collect it."

Nysa lowered the cloth. Her lip had swollen, distorting the composed expression with which she normally received unwelcome offers.

"If you can."

Crispus gathered the tablets and went out. He could be tactful when there was no advantage in remaining.

Antonia pulled a stool towards the chair. She had bought the room's painted chest from a widow who had apologised for selling it to her, then asked for the price to be paid in silver. Upon it stood a little glass bottle Nysa had once admired. Antonia found herself considering whether to give it to her. She kept her hands in her lap.

"Will a physician be wanted?"

"It is a split lip, not a siege wound."

"A physician might still know what to put on it."

"Damaris does."

"Very well."

The room had been intended for quiet conversation. Antonia had chosen every cushion herself. Now there was nowhere comfortable to look.

"He will not be admitted again," she said.

Nysa pressed the cloth between her fingers.

"He will go somewhere else."

"Not here."

"That matters to you. It may matter to the woman somewhere else rather differently."

Antonia took the remark without answering it. Through the shutters she could hear someone laughing in the street, then the scrape of a stool being dragged across stone in the room below. The last guests were gone. The house would take another hour to become clean.

"I should not have put you at his couch."

"You asked me. I agreed. I thought he would be tiresome and generous. He has been both before."

"You could have told me he had hurt you."

"He hadn't. Not like that."

There was a pause which made Antonia wonder what the qualification contained. She could ask. Nysa might even tell

her. But the question would require listening to things for which she would then bear a more exact responsibility.

She asked it anyway.

Nysa spoke without flourish. Fingers left too long on her neck. A joke about sending men to escort her if she ever forgot an appointment. Once, a payment held back until she had thanked him pleasantly enough. Nothing she had not seen with other men. Nothing that had seemed worth losing the money over, until now.

"You should have said."

Nysa looked at her, and Antonia heard how she had made the woman's silence into the easiest fault available.

"I am sorry," Antonia said.

The apology sat between them, inadequate but not withdrawn.

Nysa picked up the silver and began placing it in her purse.

"I won't come tomorrow."

"There is no dinner tomorrow."

"Or the day after. Perhaps for a while. I want to see about the shop."

She had mentioned it before: a place near the baths where a friend sold oils, hairpieces and the little necessities women bought from women because men charged more for pretending not to understand. The friend required capital. Nysa had been saving for a share.

"Do not buy it because you are angry," Antonia said.

"I thought of it when I was quite cheerful."

"I meant only that you should have someone examine the terms. Crispus could—"

"Someone who works for me."

Antonia nodded. There was a time when she would have admired that answer without finding it personally disagreeable.

Damaris came to the door. Her sleeve was wet from washing Felix. She looked at Nysa first.

"There is a man in the small court," she said. "He would not give the porter his business."

"Then the porter should not have let him in."

Damaris said the name.

Nysa stopped closing her purse. Antonia stood before she had decided to stand, and the stool scraped sharply on the floor.

"I can send him away," Damaris said.

"No."

Antonia steadied the stool, though it was no longer moving.

"No. I will see him."

She took the long way, through the passage by the storerooms, where the air was cooler and the lamps fewer. She did not examine her reflection in the polished bronze outside the garden room. She had been examined sufficiently for one evening.

Lucius Valerius Messalla stood beside the fountain with his cloak still fastened. He wore an ordinary tunic rather than the toga in which she saw him at public ceremonies. It made him look less like his father. Age had done the opposite: the deepening crease beside his mouth, the heaviness above the eyes. She had not been near him alone in many years.

He turned at the sound of her steps.

"Antonia."

"If you have come to speak about Varro, you may save yourself the trouble."

"I have not."

"Then you have chosen an inconvenient hour for whatever it is."

He looked towards the open doorway. In the room beyond, someone was lifting a couch to recover a dropped spoon.

"May we speak somewhere private?"

"You came to this house. Its privacy should be familiar to you by reputation."

"Must we begin like this?"

"We began a long time ago."

The fountain fell in an uneven sheet over its stone lip. Antonia had twice asked the gardener to have the channel cleared. Now the little obstruction made the water catch and whisper, irritatingly audible in the silence.

Messalla took a folded document from inside his cloak.

"You own a share of the Sulpician warehouses at Ostia."

"I do."

"So do I, through an estate arrangement my father made. The management has been in other hands for some years."

"You must find that restful."

"I did."

She looked at the document. He held it between two fingers, not offering it yet. He had always had neat hands. She remembered one of them reaching past her to lift the latch of a door, and shut the memory down with such force that she missed his next words.

"Say that again."

He glanced at her face, then back at the folded sheet.

"There is a debt secured on the partnership's income. I received notice of a further advance this afternoon. The schedule includes your interest among the interests bound by the undertaking."

"My accountant would know."

"Then ask him."

"I did not authorise you to examine my affairs."

"No. You authorised someone else. That is what I want to establish."

She held out her hand. After a moment he gave her the document.

The writing was clear, prepared by a clerk accustomed to making uncomfortable facts easy to read. Names. Dates. Advances against repairs, storage charges and wages. A total larger than the estimate on Crispus's table. Beneath it the

names of the participating owners, each share described with sufficient accuracy to make the paper difficult to dismiss.

She did not recognise all the names. She recognised Fabius Severus as lender and a little way below as a man empowered to receive payment.

"This is a copy," she said.

"A memorandum sent to my manager. Not the instrument itself."

"Then it proves very little."

"It proves someone intends me to pay. I assume the distinction matters to you as well."

She read the total again. The water kept catching in the channel. Her feet hurt; she had been standing for most of the day.

"Why come yourself?"

"Would you have answered a letter?"

"Depending on the letter."

"Would your accountant have told mine whether the figures were right?"

That was a more substantial question. She disliked him for recognising it.

"He might have."

"Then let him tell us both. Tomorrow. I have a meeting in the Forum during the morning. Afterwards I can bring my manager here."

"You assume a great deal."

"I assume we have separate reasons not to pay the same debt twice."

Antonia folded the memorandum along its existing creases. She knew enough of partnerships to understand that an old authority could remain inconveniently alive after everyone stopped thinking about it. She knew enough of Severus to suspect he had begun his conversation at dinner before expecting to be asked a single question. Neither amounted to proof of a wrong. Both amounted to work.

"Leave this," she said. "I will have it examined. If there is something to discuss, you may come at dusk. Not with a crowd."

"My manager is not a crowd."

"Then you should have no difficulty."

He fastened the cloak he had not unfastened. His thumb paused against the brooch, a gesture she would once have understood as the beginning of something he found difficult to say.

"I heard there was trouble tonight," he said.

"Rome has become efficient."

"Severus's man met mine in the street."

"Of course he did."

"Is anyone badly hurt?"

She looked at him until he lowered his hand.

"You may ask about the roofs tomorrow."

He went without further speech. At the doorway he waited for the porter to lift the bar, standing aside when a kitchen boy hurried through with a bucket. The boy did not recognise him. Antonia was grateful for that brief, unintentional equality.

Damaris found her still beside the fountain.

"Should I put out these lamps?"

"All but this one. Is Nysa gone?"

"I sent a man with her. She wanted him to walk behind."

"Good."

Antonia gave her the memorandum.

"Take that to Crispus in the morning. Tell him to bring the original partnership agreement, not merely the accounts. And remind me that I am to speak to him about you. Before anything else."

Damaris accepted the folded sheet. For an instant she appeared about to say something, then tucked it safely inside the cover of her household tablets.

Antonia sat on the edge of the pool after she had gone. The stone had kept a little warmth from the day. In the passage, a broom travelled steadily across the floor, gathering pastry crumbs, a broken stem and the thin flakes of a guest's discarded garland. She unfastened the pin at her shoulder and held it in her palm until the point began to hurt.

CHAPTER TWO

The Weight of a Name

Messalla woke with one arm outside the blanket and the cold stiffness that came from sleeping badly in a draught. On the other side of the bed Aelia was already sitting up. Her maid held a lamp close to a broken clasp while she examined it.

"It is the spring," Aelia said.

"It was repaired."

"It was paid for. That is not always the same thing."

The maid glanced towards Messalla, seeking permission to be amused. He gave none, and she returned her attention to the clasp. Through the shutters came the sound of a man sweeping the court. Each stroke ended with a little tap against the paving, regular enough to make further sleep impossible.

"What time is it?" he asked.

"Time for you to get up. Your clients have begun arriving."

"They would arrive in the middle of the night if I let them."

"You do let them. You are simply asleep when it happens."

He rose. A servant brought the basin and waited while he washed. The water was warm, the towel warmed beside a brazier. As a boy he had supposed every house possessed a room in which water became warm before a person thought to require it. He had learnt otherwise without learning to welcome the cold.

Aelia sent the maid away with the clasp. In the pale light her hair showed grey at the roots, an alteration she permitted only the people who lived with her to see. She reached for a cup beside the bed and drank before speaking again.

"You came in late."

"There was a matter about the Ostia property."

"At night?"

"That was when I could attend to it."

She watched him pull on his tunic. He had expected a second question, and her silence made him answer the one she had not asked.

"I went to Antonia Cassia. She has an interest in the partnership."

"I know."

"Who told you?"

"You did. Last year, when you were explaining why you would no longer ask my brother to invest in it. You said the existing owners were difficult enough."

He remembered. At the time he had believed the sentence an adequate explanation.

Aelia set down her cup.

"Will there be an expense?"

"There may be."

"Then speak to me before you decide it can be met from my account."

"I have never taken money from your account."

"You have asked for it in ways which made refusing a declaration of war."

The servant who dressed him was waiting just beyond the curtain. Messalla could see his sandalled feet, perfectly still.

"We will discuss it later."

"We usually do. Then later turns out to have been yesterday."

He pushed aside the curtain. The servant lifted the toga from its stand and began arranging the heavy wool across his shoulder. Messalla stood while the folds were drawn into position. A man could not dress himself for public dignity without assistance. His father had enjoyed observing that this taught the assistant his place. Messalla had never found the

observation especially funny, but he had repeated it once to his son.

In the atrium the waiting men stood when he appeared. There were fewer than there had been in his father's time. The difference was not necessarily a measure of decline; the city offered more patrons now, and men who had once waited at a patrician door might prosper by waiting at the door of an imperial freedman instead. Still, he counted them before he greeted them.

A shopkeeper wanted help with an assessment. A veteran needed a letter to a man who had served under a man Messalla knew. An elderly client brought his grandson to ask whether there might be a position in somebody's household office. Messalla asked if the boy could calculate. The grandfather said that he could, very well. The boy said nothing.

"How many are seven times nine?" Messalla asked.

The grandfather began to answer, caught himself, and placed a hand firmly on the boy's back.

"Sixty-three," the boy said.

"And if I owe you that many denarii and pay you twelve?"

"You owe me fifty-one."

"He will do," Messalla said.

The boy smiled. A practical problem had proved kinder than a greeting. Messalla told his secretary to write to the estate steward in Campania. There might be work, though not in Rome, and the boy must understand that before the letter was sent.

The grandfather thanked him too much. Messalla endured it because to interrupt would have seemed impatient, and because gratitude was one of the things the room had been built to contain.

When the callers were gone, he found his family eating beneath the eastern portico. Valeria had a sheet of writing beside her bowl. Publius was using a piece of bread to collect

honey from the bottom of a dish which had plainly been emptied already.

"There is more," Aelia told him.

"I am aware."

"Then why are you scraping?"

"For the pleasure of achievement."

Valeria laughed. Their father sat, and Publius straightened sufficiently to give the impression of having been straight all along.

"You are going out with Decimus today?" Messalla asked.

"To the baths. He has found a man who can teach me to fall without damaging myself."

"Begin by learning to stand without doing so."

"I have been standing for nineteen years."

"Not continuously," Valeria said.

Messalla took bread. His son had his mother's long hands, his own impatience, and an easy affection for people whose names he ought to have learnt before embracing them. At nineteen Messalla had already known which families would matter to him. He could not decide whether Publius's lack of that knowledge was innocence or negligence.

"Decimus owes money," he said.

"So do most men you dine with."

Aelia lowered her eyes to her bowl. Valeria stopped smiling.

Publius saw the effect of the answer and flushed.

"I did not mean—"

"You meant to be clever. It is a common error."

"He is my friend."

"Then be his friend without paying for it."

The young man broke off another piece of bread. No one asked whether he had already paid.

Valeria folded her sheet. Messalla noticed the care with which she aligned the edges, a gesture she had acquired from her mother after her husband's death. In the first months of

her widowhood she had left everything unfinished: cups, sentences, the fastening of her shoes. Now she completed small actions as though they proved something.

"Marcellus has asked to dine next week," he said.

She kept her fingers on the folded page.

"Has he?"

"With us."

"I understood that you did not mean he wished to dine with the emperor."

Publius looked up, encouraged by someone else risking an answer. Messalla ignored him.

"He has behaved with consideration. There is no need to make light of it."

"I was making light of your manner of telling me. Does he want a wife, or does he want dinner?"

"Valeria."

"It would help to know how much I am expected to eat."

Aelia put a hand over her daughter's wrist.

"We have agreed to a dinner," she said. "Nothing else."

Messalla had thought the matter would be easier with her support. He had forgotten that Aelia supported negotiations by insisting that they remain negotiations.

"You liked him well enough last winter."

"I still like him," Valeria said. "I like the physician who treated my cough. I have not been asked to marry him."

"Marcellus would be an honourable husband."

"My first husband was honourable. He still died."

The words were not loud. They left Publius looking at his hands.

Messalla knew what had killed the husband: a fever which had begun with ordinary complaints and ended before the family could persuade itself that the best physician had been called. He had paid the physician anyway. Aelia had said nothing about the expense.

"No one promises otherwise," he told his daughter.

"Then let us call it dinner."

After a moment he nodded. She unfolded her page again, but he saw that she did not read it.

His manager, Herennius, waited at the end of the portico with a leather case beneath his arm. Messalla rose before his family had finished. As he moved away he heard Publius ask his sister, very quietly, whether she wanted him to stay home that evening. She said no. The kindness in the question made Messalla unwilling to turn and disturb it.

Herennius had brought the old warehouse authority.

"You found it?" Messalla asked.

"In your father's chest of estate papers. There were copies with the quarterly accounts as well."

"And the limit?"

"One hundred and twenty thousand sestertii in advances against the common income, for repairs and operating expenses. Not per owner. In total."

The memorandum received the previous day put the debt at one hundred and sixty-eight thousand.

Messalla took the case. In the dining portico his wife said something about the repair of a clasp, and his son laughed with the relief of a person permitted to be young again.

• • •

The new Forum was already crowded when Messalla arrived. Men still stopped beneath its colonnades to look up, obstructing people who had learnt to pass through without admiring anything. The pale stone had not yet acquired the dark touch of so many hands. Somewhere behind a temporary screen, workmen were striking iron against stone, the noise abrupt beneath the ordered grandeur.

A client joined Messalla's little procession, walked with him for thirty paces, and detached himself after obtaining a promise. A second approached with a greeting addressed too

carefully to the width of his senatorial stripe. Herennius kept the leather case close against his body.

"Do we have to carry all of it?" Messalla asked.

"Only if you wish to look at it."

"I meant the case."

"You dislike papers folded into a sleeve."

Messalla let the matter rest. He had disliked it once, when a receipt had become unreadable with sweat. Herennius remembered every instruction as if it might become a charge against him.

Severus was waiting near a bookseller who had acquired permission, or sufficient confidence, to arrange his wares beneath the shade. He was examining a rolled text without opening it. At the sight of Messalla he paid for it and handed it to an attendant.

"For my nephew," he said. "Perhaps reading about buildings will prove less expensive than building them."

"You wished to discuss the Ostia advances."

"I hoped we might walk."

They walked. The attendants followed far enough behind for conversation to be private if neither man raised his voice. Privacy in a public place required cooperation. Messalla wondered how long Severus would provide it.

"I saw our fellow owner last night," Severus said.

"So did I."

A small change passed across the other man's face. Not surprise exactly; the adjustment of an estimate.

"Then she has told you there is some urgency about the roofs."

"She has told me very little. Herennius has found the authority. It provides for advances up to one hundred and twenty thousand. Your schedule names a larger sum."

"Interest, arrears of wages, temporary storage elsewhere. Nothing so substantial as it appears."

"Forty-eight thousand is substantial."

"To a man who cannot pay it, certainly."

Messalla stopped beside a column. Severus took two further steps before turning back.

"Was that intended as an observation about my position?"

"It was intended as an observation about arithmetic. If it sounded otherwise, forgive me."

The apology came readily, without the least suggestion of surrender. Messalla had known men like this all his adult life: useful, patient, indifferent to the advantages of losing their temper. They lent money to men who despised trade and accepted invitations from men who despised lenders. When the invitations ceased, the loans remained.

"The statements will be compared," Messalla said. "Until then I acknowledge no extension beyond the agreed limit."

"Of course. Your advisers will examine whether the interest falls within the limit or accrues upon it. They will also find that the wages had to be paid if the warehouses were to function. We could hardly tell men to work for nothing because the owners were discussing terms."

"Were the wages paid?"

"I advanced the money to Hilarus."

Hilarus was the manager at Ostia. The difference between the two answers was not proof of dishonesty, but it was large enough for a man to stand in.

Messalla signalled to Herennius, who opened the case. They stepped beneath the shade while he brought out the authority. Severus accepted the copy, read it rather than pretending to read it, and indicated a clause with a clean fingernail.

"There. Necessary preservation of common property. A storm does not wait for four owners to agree."

"The roofs were reported defective in the autumn. No storm was needed."

"And the autumn distribution was taken. By all of you. Including Antonia."

Messalla remembered the money arriving. He had applied part of it to repairs on his country house, where a wall had begun to lean towards a tenant's yard. A necessary preservation of property, his steward had called that too.

"You advised the distribution," he said.

"On Hilarus's assurance that the work could wait. I was mistaken to trust him. So were you."

A group of young men passed, laughing at a line someone had written on a tablet. One of them bowed to Messalla without stopping. He recognised the son of a man to whom he had promised an appointment, and the sight irritated him beyond its importance.

"I will speak to Hilarus," he said.

"You should. I have asked him to come to Rome. Meanwhile there is a simpler way."

Severus rolled the edge of the copy between his fingers, noticed what he was doing, and flattened it.

"I can purchase your share, subject to the advances. You would receive a clear sum. No further responsibility for roofs, freight, men or weather."

"At what valuation?"

"A fair one."

"Name it."

Severus did. It was low enough to offend, high enough to be considered by a man who required cash, and precise enough to indicate that the calculation had been made long before the conversation.

Messalla took back the document.

"The income in two good years would exceed that."

"Two good years, with sound roofs, no fire and reliable tenants. You are welcome to wait for them."

"While you collect interest."

"While my money remains employed."

He said it without embarrassment. Messalla could almost respect him for that. Almost, but not while standing beneath a

column the emperor had raised to display what money became when it ceased to be discussed as money.

"Have you made the same offer to Antonia?"

"I began to. There was an interruption."

"I heard."

"Then perhaps you understand why it may be advisable for her to simplify her affairs. A woman in her position depends upon goodwill. Quintus Varro has a family, friends. A temper too, certainly. But one does not improve a temper by humiliating its owner before witnesses."

"Was he humiliated, or did he behave badly?"

Severus glanced towards the attendants.

"Both can be true."

"And what do you expect me to do with that information?"

"Nothing. I merely explain why a sensible offer might be welcome."

Messalla had heard men praise Antonia as sensible in the same tone they used for a horse that refrained from biting. He had used that tone himself. Hearing it now did not make him innocent of it.

They resumed walking. Beyond the open space, petitioners were gathering for a hearing. A woman held a little boy on her hip while an older child guarded their bundle. No one looking at her could have mistaken waiting for idleness. Her weight shifted with every movement of the boy.

"There is a further consideration," Severus said.

Messalla waited.

"Marcellus is a friend. I should be sorry if these untidy commercial obligations intruded on arrangements which ought to concern your family alone."

The sound of workmen striking stone seemed suddenly closer.

"My daughter's affairs are not security for your loan."

"I did not say they were."

"Then keep them separate."

For the first time Severus's pleasantness became visibly an effort.

"Your father understood that an obligation does not cease because its discussion is unwelcome."

"You did little business with my father."

"Enough to be paid."

The reply was too quick to have been prepared, and therefore more revealing than anything that preceded it. Severus looked away first, towards a man greeting him from across the pavement.

"The first payment falls due on the fifteenth of May," he said. "There is time to resolve the figures without inconvenience. My clerk will bring a statement to your house. You may have someone compare it with the Ostia book."

He bowed and left before Messalla could dismiss him. His attendant hurried after him with the purchased roll.

Herennius put the authority away.

"Was my father ever late paying him?" Messalla asked.

The manager hesitated.

"You would have to ask the men who kept his accounts then."

"You knew them."

"I was junior to them."

There it was again, the refuge of rank. Messalla had required men to stay within it for years. Now he found the wall inconvenient.

He watched a seller of little cakes count change into a customer's hand. Three coins, each pressed into the waiting palm. At least one transaction in the Forum would end with both parties knowing what had happened.

"Find the records of the distribution," he told Herennius. "And a man who knows the warehouses, not just the figures. We will be called upon to pay for repairs. I would like to know whether anything has been repaired."

"Will you accept the offer?"

"No."

The answer came before he had completed the calculation. He recognised his own pride in it, and made himself add, "Not yet."

• • •

He dismissed his litter before the last turn towards Antonia's door. The street was narrow enough for two men carrying a chest to halt everyone behind them, and he preferred arriving on foot to sitting above an audience while they manoeuvred it. Herennius followed, carrying the case again.

A child crouched beside a wall, holding a broken reed over a line of ants. He looked at Messalla's shoes with interest but made no attempt to move until Herennius asked him to.

"They have gone round it," the child said.

"What have?"

He pointed. The ants had found a route along a crack in the paving.

"Sensible of them," Messalla said.

The boy considered this as if he had expected a less reasonable answer. Then a woman called from within the doorway and he picked up his reed.

Damaris admitted them. She looked first at Messalla, then at Herennius and the case, making an inventory without discourtesy. Her tunic was plain and well kept. At her waist hung the household keys.

"Antonia is in the garden room."

She did not call her mistress, but that did not make her free. Messalla had noticed how often wealthy houses mistook a comfortable form of address for an alteration in the people using it.

Antonia sat at a low table with Crispus opposite. A third stool had been placed beside them, and a fourth against the

wall. The positioning left Messalla no choice about where to sit without making his preference a subject of conversation.

He remained standing until she indicated the stool.

"You have brought what we need?" she asked.

"The authority and our accounts."

"Crispus has ours. Sit down."

There was no wine. Damaris brought water, four cups, and bread which no one had requested. Messalla was hungry enough to be grateful. He waited until Antonia took a piece before touching it.

Crispus unrolled a sheet and placed a weight at either end.

"Before the figures," Antonia said, "my steward needs something from your manager."

Messalla looked towards Damaris. She had not left the doorway.

"I was told you might know a man accustomed to petitions concerning manumission," she said to Herennius. "Not someone who promises results before he hears the circumstances."

Herennius looked at Messalla. It was a brief glance, but Antonia saw it and her mouth hardened.

"You may answer her," Messalla said.

"I know a clerk who prepares papers for an advocate," Herennius told Damaris. "He has dealt with such matters. Is the person under thirty?"

"My son is ten. I am not."

"Then he will need the circumstances. The reason, the relationship, the proposed form. He cannot say what is possible from an age alone."

"I want to hear him myself."

"That can be arranged."

Antonia rested her hand flat on the table.

"Crispus spoke to me this morning. We will pay for advice. Damaris may give the circumstances herself. I want no promise made to her which cannot be kept."

The woman bowed her head, but not before Messalla saw her expression. She had heard promises already. He wondered whether Antonia knew it. The question was answered by the care with which she avoided looking at the keys.

Herennius gave the clerk's name and where he could be found. Damaris repeated both, then took an unused tablet from a shelf and wrote them down. She left only when she had checked the writing against the spoken directions.

"Now," Antonia said.

Crispus began with the original agreement. Antonia's patron had bought her interest before Antonia herself was free. Messalla's father had acquired his earlier, through a loan settled partly in property. Between them the two households owned seven twelfths: a quarter to Antonia, a third to Messalla. The remaining shares belonged to two mercantile families, one of which had recently suffered a death.

"Their executors may be selling," Herennius said.

"May be?" Crispus asked.

"There was an enquiry."

"From Severus?"

"Yes."

Antonia tapped a finger against her cup and stopped when she noticed Messalla noticing it.

"Let us decide what we know," she said. "Not what we would enjoy suspecting."

It was almost exactly what Messalla had intended to say. Hearing her say it first annoyed him more than the sentiment deserved.

They compared the distributions. Money had been taken in the autumn which could have paid for the west roofs. Antonia had received her portion. Messalla had received his. The other owners had done the same. Hilarus had assured all of them that there was no immediate danger.

"The assurance did not travel with the timber estimate," Crispus said. "That arrived three weeks afterwards."

"Was it accepted?" Messalla asked.

"Not by us."

"By anyone?"

Herennius found a letter. There was no final acceptance, merely a request to hold the price pending instructions. The price had not been held. Meanwhile Hilarus had hired labourers, dismissed some, retained others, and claimed expenses for moving grain out of two rooms which were not yet watertight.

Messalla listened to sums which represented acts he could picture only imperfectly. Men carrying sacks across a yard. A room empty of grain but still costing money. Rain falling into a vessel which someone had to empty. He had seen all these things separately. The accounts brought them together and made his ignorance expensive.

"You are saying the advance was necessary," he said.

"I am saying some of it may have been," Crispus answered. "It would help to see the rooms."

"And the book," Antonia said.

"The book can be made to look tidier than a room."

Messalla looked at the older man. Crispus did not apologise for having contradicted him without quite contradicting him at all.

Outside, the child from the street began explaining something to Damaris. She listened to three sentences before telling him to wash his hands. He asked whether both hands were necessary. Antonia closed her eyes briefly, and Messalla recognised the effort not to smile.

"Is that your steward's son?" he asked.

"Felix."

The name meant fortunate. It was common enough that no one needed to remark on it. He was aware nevertheless of

Antonia looking at him, and turned back to the accounts too quickly.

She drew a folded sheet from beneath the edge of the papyrus.

"Your memorandum includes wages. Crispus has a letter from one of the contractors asking why his men have not been paid. It came this afternoon, after he had already asked twice at Ostia."

"He may have received payment since writing."

"He may. That is one thing we can establish."

Messalla read the letter. The hand was awkward, the anger not. Four men had worked eleven days; a fifth had been retained for six. The writer said he had fed them on his own money and could not continue. He wanted to know who was entitled to dismiss them, since two different men had claimed that right.

"This should have gone to Hilarus," Messalla said.

"It did. Twice."

"Then to the partnership agent."

"Whose address is Hilarus's office."

He set the letter down.

"You could have answered it."

Antonia's face changed. Not much, but enough that he regretted making the remark in front of their servants.

"So could you, if he had known where to find you. He found me because I gave his wife work after her last employer died. The roofs did not concern her until he stopped being paid."

The domestic fact landed with an unpleasant solidity. Messalla had been seeking the proper route for a complaint. The man had been seeking anyone who might read it.

"Then we should go," he said.

"Yes."

"Tomorrow I can send—"

"Not send. Go."

He looked at her.

"I have business here."

"So have I. This has become part of it."

"We cannot both abandon everything every time a manager fails to write a satisfactory letter."

"Then you need not come. I will tell you what I find, and you may decide whether to believe it."

He could not tell whether she intended the choice to be insulting. That she might not have considered his pride at all was worse.

Herennius began putting the letters in order, a discreet suggestion that the discussion could be concluded without further injuries. Messalla placed his hand on the leather case before the manager could close it.

"The day after tomorrow," he said. "We leave early. I have obligations tomorrow which cannot be transferred."

Antonia considered him. He had expected immediate agreement; instead she consulted Crispus, who reminded her of a merchant due to pay a balance. She told him to receive it himself.

"The day after tomorrow," she said. "We should meet outside the city. There is no need to provide an entertainment for the neighbours."

"At the gate."

"With someone who knows how long the road takes. I do not propose to spend half the day waiting for your litter."

"You have acquired a very exact picture of my habits."

"Your habits are not difficult to see."

Crispus rose to fetch a copy of the contractor's letter. Herennius followed, offering to make it himself, and the two men went towards the account room discussing whose ink would serve. Their departure was sufficiently natural that Messalla suspected neither of planning it. He found himself alone with Antonia without an excuse to ask for it.

She gathered the empty cups. He wanted to tell her not to do a servant's task, then understood how the words would sound in this room.

"Severus offered to buy my share," he said.

"Mine too, though he did not get as far as a price."

He named the sum. Antonia gave a short, disbelieving laugh.

"You could almost admire the accuracy. It is just enough not to be ridiculous."

"I declined."

"For now?"

He looked up. She was stacking the cups, testing one against another to prevent them from sticking.

"For now," he admitted.

"Good. I would rather know when you are considering it."

"Do you imagine I would sell without telling you?"

Her hands stopped.

The question lay between them before he heard all of it. In the garden a leaf moved against the stone border. From the account room came Crispus's voice asking for a sharper knife to trim the pen.

Messalla could have altered the question. He was good at that. A change of emphasis, a qualification about commercial obligations, and they would both be required to behave as though he had meant nothing else.

He did not alter it.

Antonia set the cups down separately.

"I imagine," she said, "that I should read everything before it is signed."

He felt the heat rise along his neck. There was no answer he could give which would not require another, and he had spent too many years allowing that fact to determine what he said.

"Yes," he told her. "You should."

She looked at him then, not softened, not satisfied. Merely surprised that he had left the sentence where it was.

Crispus returned with the copy before either of them spoke again. Herennius had written the contractor's name more clearly beneath the original hand, but marked it as a transcription rather than letting the new writing pass for the man's own. Messalla folded the sheet and thanked him.

At the door, Felix stood with both hands held out for Damaris's inspection. The left still had dirt beneath the nails. She sent him back with a basin, and he passed Messalla carrying it as solemnly as a votive offering.

On the way home Herennius asked whether he should arrange fresh bearers for the journey. Messalla said yes, then asked what had happened to the old ones.

"One is ill. Two have been sent to the country house. I thought you knew."

He had not. It was not a matter he normally required his manager to tell him.

"Get men who are paid for the day," he said. "And find out whether the ill man has seen a physician."

Herennius nodded. A simple instruction, easily obeyed. Messalla felt the temptation to take pleasure in it and resisted as far as he could.

At home he found Aelia sitting beside the open chest in which she kept her private accounts. She had changed into a plain gown. A lamp stood on the floor near her feet, bringing up the smell of warmed wool.

"I am going to Ostia," he said.

"I assumed someone would have to."

"The day after tomorrow. There may be a payment in May. I do not know how much. I will tell you when I do."

She looked up from the chest. He could see her deciding whether to reward him for telling her what she had asked to know that morning. She chose not to.

"Marcellus has confirmed next week," she said.

"Dinner only."

"That is what Valeria has agreed to."

He sat on the bench beside her. For a while neither spoke. From another part of the house came the sound of Publius losing a game to his sister and attempting to explain why the loss should not count.

Aelia reached into the chest and took out a folded statement.

"My brother has borrowed from Severus," she said. "He has asked me to stand behind part of it. I have not agreed."

Messalla looked at the sheet, but did not reach for it.

"How much?"

She told him. He waited while she explained what the money was for, who had already promised to contribute, and why she believed one part of the proposal but not another. He asked a question. She answered it. Outside the circle of lamplight the room grew dark, and for once he did not summon anyone to bring another lamp before she had finished.

CHAPTER THREE

River Weather

Damaris learnt that she was to go to Ostia while she was folding a sheet that did not need folding.

It had come back from the laundry stiff at the corners and smelling faintly of ash. She had shaken it once, found a tear along the lower edge, and set it across her arms so that she could carry it to Meroe for mending. Antonia stopped her beside the storeroom door.

"You will come with me tomorrow," she said.

Damaris looked down at the linen. "Where?"

"To the warehouses. We leave before dawn."

"Does Crispus know?"

"He is staying here. A merchant is bringing the balance he owes, and if no one is here to receive it he will decide that courtesy requires him to keep it for another month."

"And Felix?"

Antonia's expression altered, not enough for a stranger to notice. She had clearly arranged the sentence in the order that suited her and had not expected the interruption so soon.

"Meroe can keep him."

"Meroe has the mending for three rooms and a shoulder that pains her when it rains."

"Then the cook."

"The cook lets him eat from the serving dishes and calls it education."

Antonia took one corner of the sheet, as if helping would return the conversation to its proper course. Damaris did not release the other end.

"Who would you choose?" Antonia asked.

"Meroe, if someone else takes the mending. And Crispus must look in after supper. Felix will pretend he is not waiting to be afraid until the house is quiet."

"Very well."

"He has a loose tooth. It is not to be tied to anything."

"I shall make a household law."

Damaris folded the sheet properly this time, tear side out so Meroe would see it. The ordinary details steadied her. She could make lists for a child left behind. She was less certain what list could be made for herself.

"Why me?" she asked.

"Because you know what work looks like when it has been done and when someone has merely been paid to describe it. Herennius will read the documents. Messalla and I will listen to Hilarus explain himself. I need another pair of eyes."

"You have eyes."

"I have a temper. It occasionally uses them first."

That startled a smile out of Damaris despite her intention to remain exact. Antonia saw it and, being Antonia, tried to make use of the softened moment.

"We shall be gone a day, perhaps two."

"Then my appointment?"

The smile left Damaris's face before Antonia could answer.

"Crispus sent word this morning," Antonia said. "The clerk Herennius named will see us when we return. You may speak to him yourself, as we agreed."

"Did he name a day?"

"Not yet."

"No."

Antonia's hand tightened on the sheet. "No?"

"No unnamed days. If he cannot name one, find another man."

They stood in the passage with clean linen between them. From the kitchen came the sound of bowls being set down too

hard, then the cook denying that anything had broken. Damaris could hear Thaleia practising in the garden room, stopping each time at the same difficult run of notes.

"I will tell Crispus," Antonia said at last. "A day, or another clerk."

"Thank you."

It was not gratitude, precisely. It was acknowledgement that a thing had been said where both of them could remember it.

Preparations occupied the rest of the morning. Damaris made three bundles and then, dissatisfied, made them again. Cloaks against weather that might not come. Bread and cheese for the road because Antonia disliked arriving hungry enough to be gracious. A small pot of the salve used for harness sores and human hands. Needle, thread, a spare strap. The household offered suggestions according to temperament. The cook wanted dried figs included. The gardener recommended a hat. Crispus appeared with a document case wrapped in oiled cloth and the expression of a man handing over an infant to indifferent relatives.

"Copies," he said. "Partnership agreement, authority, the last two statements from Hilarus. The contractor's letter is the original. Antonia insisted."

"Why?"

"Because if Hilarus calls the handwriting counterfeit, she wants him to do it while looking at it."

"And if it rains?"

"Then you will keep it dry. That appears to be among your duties."

He showed her how the case fastened. Inside, each sheet had been rolled separately and tied. Crispus had written brief labels in his small, upright hand. There was also a blank sheet, folded once.

"For what you see," he said.

"Antonia can remember."

"People remember what assists them. Write it down before it learns manners."

Damaris put the case with her own bundle. She had kept accounts of other people's property for years. It felt different to be asked for a record in her own words, though she suspected Crispus would laugh at the distinction and Antonia would file it under something else.

Felix found her in the afternoon, when she was instructing the laundry woman about the sheets for a dinner two nights later. He had a wooden horse in one hand and half a honey cake in the other.

"Meroe says you are going to the sea."

"Near it."

"Will you see a ship sleeping?"

"Ships do not sleep."

"They stop."

"Then I may see one stopped."

He considered this compromise acceptable. Honey had reached his wrist. Damaris took the cake, broke off the sticky edge and ate it before he could protest.

"How long is tomorrow?" he asked.

"We leave before it is light. If the road is good, perhaps we return the next day."

"Two sleeps?"

"Perhaps."

He turned the horse over and examined its painted legs. One had been chewed, years ago, by a child who now denied all knowledge of the event.

"You could take me."

"No."

"I can carry things."

"You can lose things beautifully."

"I could carry the case."

"No."

He waited for anger or relenting. Finding neither, he reached into the fold of his tunic and produced a flat grey pebble.

"Take this, then."

"Why?"

"So the road knows you are coming back."

Damaris put the pebble into the small pouch at her waist. The gesture pleased him far more than agreement to take him probably would have done.

"Will Antonia come back too?"

"Yes."

"Then the road knows already."

"It helps to remind roads."

He ran off to tell the cook, who would receive the information as a reason to give him more cake. Damaris watched until he turned the corner. Later she told Meroe about the tooth, the night lamp, the story he liked and the one he claimed to like but always interrupted. Meroe listened with a needle between her lips.

"You have told me all this before," she said.

"Then you can correct me if I forget anything."

"I shall correct him. It is more useful."

After supper she found Felix in Meroe's room, already installed as if the arrangement were a festival invented for his benefit. He had placed his wooden horse on the pillow and a stolen crust beneath it, for the night.

"The horse does not eat," Damaris said.

"It might learn."

"Then it can begin after you are asleep."

He allowed her to wash his face but negotiated over his neck. Meroe, mending by the last light from the courtyard, ruled in Damaris's favour because, she said, a boy who left particular places unwashed eventually became a map. Felix liked the idea enough to submit.

"When I am free," he said suddenly, "can a horse be mine?"

Damaris's hands paused in the basin. Meroe's needle did not.

"Your horse is yours," Damaris said.

"I mean a real one."

"Real ones eat more than crusts."

"I could work."

"You already believe carrying one basket entitles you to sit down for the afternoon."

He grinned, and the loose tooth showed. She was grateful for the joke she had made and resentful that it had been necessary. Children repeated the words around them without asking whether the words had somewhere safe to land. She had spoken of freedom carefully. Apparently not carefully enough, or perhaps care had been understood as importance.

"Sleep," she told him. "Ask me about horses when I come back."

"Will you know more then?"

"I may know what a stopped ship looks like."

It was sufficient. He curled around the wooden horse with the crust displaced to a position of honour beneath his chin. Meroe waited until his breathing changed before saying, "He hears Crispus through doors."

"Then Crispus can lower his voice."

"He does. Felix improves his hearing."

Damaris laughed quietly. The room smelt of wool, lamp oil and the dried herbs Meroe kept against moths. For a moment she wanted to remain there, among unfinished seams and a sleeping child, rather than discover what sort of honesty a warehouse required. Wanting it did not oblige the morning to change.

At dusk Damaris laid out her travelling clothes: the darker tunic, a shawl that could serve as a hood, shoes already worn enough not to punish her feet. She transferred the household keys to Crispus in the account room and stood for a moment with empty hands, surprised by the lightness at her waist.

He held the keys as if they might accuse him.

"I shall give them back," he said.

"You had better. I know where everything is."

"That is why Antonia is taking you."

"No. She is taking me because she wants someone there who cannot be sent out of the room when the talking becomes difficult."

Crispus looked at her over the lamp. "Can you not?"

"Of course I can. But she would have to notice herself doing it."

He placed the keys on the table, carefully, in the exact place from which she usually took them in the morning.

• • •

The carriage came while the stars were still visible between the roofs.

It was a hired raeda, high-wheeled, with leather curtains and a driver who apologised to the mules before he apologised to anyone else. Damaris liked him for that. Antonia climbed in wearing a plain cloak over a dark dress, her hair bound for travel rather than admiration. The document case went between Damaris's feet. A basket occupied the remaining space and gave off the smell of bread through its cloth.

They crossed the waking city slowly. Bakers were opening shutters. A line of men waited outside a public latrine with the patience of people whose conversation had begun before necessity. Somewhere above them a woman emptied a basin into the street, calling a warning after the water rather than before it. The driver turned the mules without comment.

Messalla waited outside the Ostian Gate beside a tomb whose inscription had been half worn away by weather and passing hands. He was on horseback. Herennius stood with a second horse and a baggage mule, holding a cup he appeared

to have borrowed from the gate-side seller and not yet returned.

"You are late," Messalla said.

Antonia leaned from the carriage. "By whose reckoning?"

"The sun is not up."

"Then perhaps you are early."

Herennius returned the cup. Damaris saw him hide a smile by attending to a strap that did not require attention.

They set off along the Ostian road with the river somewhere to their right beyond gardens, kilns and rows of tombs. At first the carriage curtain stayed open. The air smelt of wet earth and crushed green stalks. A barge moved on the Tiber, towed by men who leaned into the rope as one animal might lean into weather. On the road, carts of vegetables came towards Rome, their drivers walking beside loaded mules and calling greetings to people they could not possibly all know.

Antonia read Crispus's labels again, although the light made it an unnecessary strain.

"Hilarus expects us near midday," she said.

"Then he has had time to sweep," Damaris replied.

"Do you think he is dishonest?"

"I think a man expecting owners usually finds a broom."

Antonia put the documents down. "You are to tell me what you notice. Not only if I ask."

"Even if Messalla is there?"

"Especially then. He is less likely to lose his temper before a witness."

"Am I a witness?"

The carriage wheel found a stone. Antonia waited until the jolt had passed.

"You are there."

It was not the same thing, and they both knew it. Yet in Antonia's mouth it was a kind of admission. Damaris let it stand.

Near the seventh milestone a harness strap broke with a sound like a small whip. The driver stopped beside a smith's open shed where a boy was blowing the forge into reluctant life. Messalla dismounted before Herennius could object and held the nearer mule while the strap was examined. He knew where to put his hand so the animal would not swing its head into him. Damaris had seen senators on horses at processions; she had seldom seen one being useful beside a road.

Antonia noticed her noticing.

"Do not make a character out of a strap," she murmured.

"I was making an allowance for the mule."

The smith had no finished replacement but could stitch and rivet the old leather. They waited in the yard while smoke found its way into everyone's clothes. The smith's wife brought water in a clay cup and refused payment from Antonia, then accepted it from Damaris because, she said, women knew what things cost. Messalla bought three hot chickpea cakes from a passing seller and gave one to the driver, one to Herennius, and one—after a fractional pause—to Damaris.

She thanked him. He nodded as if the exchange had embarrassed him by becoming visible.

The delay cost them the better part of an hour. Clouds had gathered from the sea by the time they moved again, flattening the light. Swallows cut low over the fields. The Tiber showed brown between trees, its surface roughened by a wind that had not yet reached the road.

"River weather," the driver said.

"Meaning rain?" Antonia asked.

"Meaning the river has decided something. We shall learn what."

At a roadside inn they ate bread, salt pork and early greens dressed with vinegar. The innkeeper wanted to place Damaris with the servants by the kitchen door. Antonia, without

looking up from her cup, said that the case between Damaris's feet contained papers she needed and that the end of the bench would do. It was not an invitation to equality. It was an arrangement that allowed Damaris to eat sitting down. Herennius slid the dish of greens towards her when the innkeeper had gone.

"Crispus writes a clear label," he said.

"He would label the rain if it stayed still."

"Would he be wrong?"

"He would call it one rain when it was becoming another."

Herennius laughed, then sobered because Messalla had unfolded his transcription of the contractor's letter.

"Four men, eleven days," Messalla said. "A fifth, six. We need the names."

"Hilarus will have tallies," Herennius said.

"He may have tallies of something."

Antonia broke her bread. "Ask the contractor."

"If he is there."

"Ask the men," Damaris said.

Both men looked at her. She had spoken more firmly than she intended, but retreat would not improve it.

"A tally can say a man was paid after he has gone hungry. If you want to know whether money reached him, ask him where he spent it."

Messalla considered her. She felt the old instruction of her life telling her to soften the sentence, to make it an apology for having had a thought. She kept her hands around her cup.

"Yes," he said. "We will."

Antonia said nothing. Her silence had an approving quality that Damaris distrusted because it might only mean she had found a useful instrument.

Farther on, the driver stopped to water the mules at a trough where the towpath came close to the road. A barge laden with amphorae was being hauled against the current, the tow-men walking in a loose line, ropes over their

shoulders. Their leader called the pace without looking back. When the barge swung wide, all of them adjusted in the same instant, as if the knowledge had travelled through the rope.

Damaris got down to stretch her legs. One of the men had bound a strip of sacking around a bleeding heel. She took the spare linen from her bundle and offered it.

"That is for us," Antonia said from the carriage.

"We have more."

"We have exactly what Crispus counted."

"Then he counted more than we need."

Antonia regarded her, but did not call the linen back. The tow-man thanked Damaris and wrapped his heel with the speed of long practice. His name, when she asked, was Eutyches. He told her the river had risen during the night although there had been little rain near Rome. Water arrived from other people's weather.

Messalla, who had dismounted to let his horse drink, asked whether the barges were still reaching the warehouses without delay.

"Empty ones go down fast enough," Eutyches said. "Full ones come up when we bring them."

It was not insolence. It was information with its bones showing. Herennius, who had taken out his tablets to note the state of the road, wrote something down. Damaris hoped it was the sentence and not merely the river height.

Back in the carriage Antonia said, "You give away my linen and make acquaintances of tow-men."

"I gave away your linen. The acquaintance was his own work."

"You will question every worker between here and Ostia."

"Only the ones whose names might be needed."

Antonia looked out at the river. "That could be all of them."

"Yes."

They reached Ostia in the early afternoon. The town pressed close around the road: warehouses, shrines, shops,

apartment blocks with washing suspended above narrow streets. Salt and grain dust hung in the air. Beyond the roofs the masts at the river mouth rose like a second, leafless grove. Felix's stopped ships would have satisfied him.

The driver turned into a courtyard where sacks were being carried from a cart to an arched doorway. The Sulpician warehouses were brick-faced and substantial, built to make permanence visible. Their tiled roofs stepped down towards the river. From ground level they looked sound enough. Damaris had learnt that roofs, like reputations, were best examined from underneath.

• • •

Hilarus came out wiping his hands on a cloth that left them dirtier than before.

He was younger than Damaris had expected, perhaps forty, with the careful cheerfulness of a man who had prepared several greetings and could not now remember which belonged to which visitor. He bowed to Messalla, bowed more deeply to Antonia, and apologised for the state of the courtyard because two deliveries had arrived together.

"We are not here to admire the courtyard," Antonia said. "Show us the west rooms."

"The office first? There is wine. Bread. The book is—"

"The rooms."

Hilarus led them beneath an arch. The first warehouse was cool and smelt of grain, mouse urine and damp plaster. Sacks stood on timber pallets, but not everywhere; in one corner they rested directly on brick, with a dark tide-mark climbing the wall behind them. A shallow vessel under a roof beam held brown water. Someone had recently emptied it and missed the floor by enough to leave a fan-shaped stain.

Messalla looked up. Daylight showed between tiles where the battens had rotted.

"When was grain last stored under that?" he asked.

"Not since the move," Hilarus said.

"When was the move?"

"When the defect became apparent."

"That is an event, not a date."

Hilarus turned to Herennius for rescue. Herennius was writing.

The second room was empty except for brooms, a ladder and stacks of short timber cut to uneven lengths. Some battens were new and pale. Others had been taken down and leaned against the wall, black at the ends. Damaris pressed her thumb into one. The wood gave like stale bread.

Antonia saw. "The estimate mentioned long timbers."

"They were ordered," Hilarus said. "Delivery has been difficult. The river—"

"Everything here arrives by river."

"Costs have risen."

"So Crispus tells me. So has my interest."

Hilarus laughed with relief because she had made what might be a joke. Neither owner joined him.

In the third room the grain had been moved and stacked with greater care. Porters worked in pairs, carrying sacks from a handcart to the pallets. One man, broad through the shoulders and greying at the temples, shifted a sack without being told when he saw that it leaned. He glanced at the visitors, then at Hilarus, and became suddenly industrious in a way Damaris recognised. She had used the same expression when Antonia's guests entered a room where work had paused for breath.

Messalla walked the length of the room. He touched nothing. His restraint made the sacks appear more fragile than they were.

"Who moved this?" he asked.

"Our regular men. Some additional labour."

"Names."

"In the office."

"Everything is in the office," Antonia said. "It must be crowded."

Hilarus led them there before she could make the remark permanent. The office was a narrow room with a high window, shelves of tablets, a strongbox beneath the desk and a smell of old ink. On the desk lay the partnership book, its cover polished by hands. It looked reassuringly used. Damaris distrusted objects that performed their own reliability.

Herennius opened it. "This is a fair copy."

Hilarus blinked. "It is the book."

"The entries for the autumn are in one hand and one ink."

"Our clerk recopied after damage from the roof."

"Where is the damaged original?"

"Burnt. It smelt."

Antonia took the contractor's letter from Damaris and placed it on the desk. She did not unfold it.

"Titus Vibius says his men were not paid."

Hilarus looked at the folded sheet as if it might unfold itself. "Vibius drinks."

"Many men do. It can make them thirsty, but not invent eleven days."

"He was advanced money."

"How much?"

"For materials."

"Which materials?"

"There were nails. Rope. Food for the men while they waited for instructions."

Messalla said, "Your statement to Severus describes wages paid."

"It describes wages advanced to me for payment."

The distinction landed in the room and stayed there.

Outside, a porter called for the cart to be moved. Wind worried at the high window. Somewhere on the roof a loose tile clicked.

Damaris said, "I need water."

Hilarus looked relieved to have an ordinary request. "In the courtyard. The boy will—"

"I can find it."

Antonia gave her a look which contained no permission that anyone else could have recognised. Damaris went out with the empty cup from the office.

The broad-shouldered porter was beside the well, washing grain dust from his forearms. Up close he was older than she had first thought, with a scar through one eyebrow and hands scaled dry from sacks.

"Is the water good?" she asked.

"Better than the roof's."

She filled the cup but did not drink immediately. "You moved grain from the west room."

"Most of Ostia has moved that grain, by the accounts."

"Did Vibius's men do the roof work?"

He shook water from his hands. "Who is asking?"

"Damaris. I keep Antonia's house."

"Keep it, do you?"

"Most days it stays where I put it."

That earned her a brief, unwilling smile.

"Nicanor," he said. "I was the fifth man. Six days carrying, damping down dust, holding ladders when the others were above. Vibius fed us twice from his own purse. Hilarus gave meal tallies at the baker's and said the owners in Rome had not released the wage money."

"Were you paid anything?"

"Two days. In coin. The baker took the rest of what he thought we owed him for being hungry after the tallies ran out."

Damaris looked towards the office. Through the doorway she could see Herennius's back and the edge of Antonia's cloak.

"The long timbers," she said. "Were they ever here?"

Nicanor dried his arms on his tunic. "Twelve good lengths. I helped unload them. Two nights later they went out again."

"Where?"

"To a salt shed downriver. Hilarus said they were too green for this roof and would be exchanged. Maybe they were. Green wood twists. But no exchange came back before the men were dismissed."

"Would you say that inside?"

"I would like work next week."

"I know."

"Then you know the answer."

She drank at last. The water tasted of stone. Above the courtyard the clouds had lowered into a single grey field. The porters had begun covering the cart with a tarpaulin, arguing good-naturedly about whose knot had failed during the last rain.

"If the owners pay Vibius, he may keep what he says he advanced and you may see nothing again," Damaris said. "If they pay men directly, they need names and days. I cannot promise Hilarus will not know who spoke. I can promise I will not give him your name as a tale. It will be on a wage receipt or nowhere."

Nicanor studied her. She understood the calculation because she made it herself whenever Antonia asked her to speak plainly. Plain speech was safest for the person requesting it.

"Get Vibius," he said. "He lives past the fullers. His wife will know where he is pretending not to drink. If he stands there, I will."

Rain began while Damaris was crossing the courtyard: first a scatter on the tiles, then a general darkening of brick. She reached the office as water found the defective roof above it and produced a bright, deliberate drip onto the corner of Hilarus's desk.

Everyone looked up.

Damaris put the cup down and moved the partnership book out of the way. The drip struck the wood where it had been.

"That," Antonia said, "is timely."

Hilarus found a bowl.

Damaris drew Antonia a little aside and told her what Nicanor had said. She named no conclusion about the timber, only the unloading and removal. Antonia listened with her eyes on the rain-dark courtyard.

"Send for Vibius," she told Hilarus.

"He is not—"

"Send for him. And bring out the wage tallies, the baker's account and the strongbox."

"The strongbox contains money reserved for cartage."

"Then we shall all admire how responsibly it has been reserved."

Messalla asked Damaris, "The man will repeat this?"

"If Vibius is present."

"And if his account differs from the tallies?"

"Then you will have two accounts instead of one. It is an improvement if you read both."

For an instant she thought she had gone too far. Messalla's face tightened, but what followed was not anger. It was the discomfort of a man realising that a sentence uttered in a slave's hearing could not be unsaid merely by looking at her.

"Yes," he said again.

Vibius arrived wet to the knees, smelling faintly of wine and more strongly of resentment. With him came two of the roof men. Nicanor joined them under the office portico. The fourth roofer sent word by his brother that he was unloading at the river and would come when released; Vibius produced a tally with his mark. Nobody treated the tally as sufficient by itself.

The days were established in the ordinary, unsatisfying way: by memory, marks, the baker's boy summoned with a tablet, and Hilarus conceding points only when they had been

made too specific to refuse. Four men, eleven days on roof and clearance. Nicanor, six days carrying and ladder work. Fifty days in all. The agreed rate had been eight sestertii a day. Four hundred were owed in wages, less two days' coin already paid to Nicanor and meal tallies whose value Vibius and the baker described so differently that Herennius put his pen down.

"We are not settling the baker today," Antonia said.

"We are not settling Severus's advance either," Messalla said.

"No. We are settling whether men who worked under this roof were paid for it."

Hilarus opened the strongbox. Inside were two hundred and thirty-six sestertii in mixed coin, a sealed packet for tolls and three lead tokens whose purpose he explained twice without improving the explanation.

"Cartage," he said.

Damaris watched Nicanor look at the money and then deliberately at the rain. Hunger could make a man theatrical. So could being managed.

Antonia took her travelling purse from Damaris. She counted one hundred and sixty-four sestertii onto the desk.

Messalla put a hand over the coins. "If we pay the whole sum now, Hilarus's accounts will show the wages discharged. Severus will say his advance accomplished it."

"Then Herennius will write what occurred."

"It may still be used."

"Anything may be used. That is not the same as allowing it to govern."

"It is partnership money you are adding from your own purse."

"Record it as my advance against wages actually earned. Not against the roof, not against interest, not against whatever Severus chooses to call preservation."

He withdrew his hand. "And my assent is limited to the same."

"Write it," Antonia told Herennius.

The men were paid one by one, with the paid days read aloud and each man making his mark or signing his name. Nicanor received the balance for four days after the two already paid. Vibius was not handed the men's money, a detail he noticed loudly and then, seeing Nicanor's face, accepted. His own claim for food advanced was written separately, to be examined against the baker's account. No one called this justice. It had the smaller virtue of being specific.

When the absent roofer arrived, wet through and apologising to the doorway, the reading was repeated. Damaris held the receipt sheet beneath the portico so that the rain would not take the ink. Her sleeve became damp through. The man made his mark with a hand still trembling from work or weather.

Hilarus stood apart, watching money leave his strongbox under other people's authority.

"The timber tally tomorrow," Antonia told him. "And the name of the carter who took the long lengths downriver."

His face changed.

"They were exchanged."

"Tomorrow you may show us the exchange."

"Severus's agent arranged—"

"Tomorrow."

Messalla added, "No further advance is to be accepted in the partnership's name without written instruction from the owners. No distribution until the roofs are sound. You may tell anyone who objects that you are obeying the majority interest."

Hilarus nodded. Whether the instruction would bind absent partners or survive the next persuasive visitor remained untested. It was nevertheless spoken before witnesses and

written by Herennius, which gave it more substance than most intentions Damaris had seen carried out of a room.

The rain thickened over the courtyard. Water ran from the sound roofs in bright ropes and dripped through the unsound ones with maddening patience. Returning to Rome that evening was no longer sensible; rooms were found nearby, one for Antonia and Damaris, one for Messalla and Herennius across the passage. The innkeeper's daughter brought a brazier and lent Damaris a dry shawl without being asked.

Antonia sat with the receipt sheet while Damaris wrung out her sleeve over a basin.

"Keep a copy with the household records when Crispus makes one," Antonia said.

"Herennius has the original."

"Then Crispus will copy from his."

"Why do we need it in the house?"

"Because you found the man."

Damaris took the pebble from her pouch to keep it from the damp and set it beside the lamp. It looked ordinary and slightly accusatory.

"Nicanor found the water," she said. "I was thirsty."

Antonia folded the receipt along lines Herennius had already made. "Do not make yourself smaller than the day requires."

Outside, the river wind worried at the shutters. Damaris listened to rain striking tiles that were not hers to repair and thought of Felix telling Meroe why both hands might not require washing. She hoped the tooth had stayed where it belonged. She hoped the road would be passable in the morning. When Antonia fell asleep with the document case beside her bed, Damaris remained awake a little longer, recording on Crispus's blank sheet the things she had seen before they could learn better manners.

CHAPTER FOUR

A Portion for a Daughter

The cups had been arranged in two rows, which made them look less like household silver than troops awaiting an unfavourable report.

Valeria counted twelve. Her mother counted twelve. Onesimus, who had served the Caecilii since before her marriage, counted twelve and then, with a small movement of his lips, counted them again.

"Eight came with the dowry," he said.

"I know."

"Four belonged to the late master's father."

"I know that too. What I do not know is which four."

Onesimus opened the inventory tablet. The wax had been smoothed and rewritten often enough to shine. "The older set is described as having vine handles."

"They all have vine handles."

"The older cups are heavier."

She picked up two, one in each hand. One was perhaps heavier. It was also the cup Gaius had preferred because a dent near the foot kept it from rocking on their uneven table. He had turned it without thinking while he listened to other people, his thumb finding the damaged place. She could still feel, absurdly, the annoyance of watching him do it.

Valeria set it down apart from the others.

Aelia said, "We could weigh them."

Onesimus looked grateful for a procedure. The household steward was sent for scales. While they waited, Valeria read the inventory again, although she knew it by heart: money,

land near Tibur, clothing, jewellery, eight silver cups, two serving dishes, household linen. Three years of marriage reduced to columns because columns could survive being carried from house to house.

Her husband had died in October. It was now May, and spring had committed the indecent act of arriving anyway. The garden outside the dining room was loud with birds. Someone in the kitchen was chopping greens in a rhythm too cheerful to be trusted.

"Marcus does not wish to distress you," Onesimus said.

"Then he has sent the wrong list."

"He has obligations to his mother."

"And I have obligations to the truth of the list. We can distress one another accurately."

Aelia placed a hand over Valeria's wrist. It might have been comfort. It might have been a warning. With her mother, the two were often administered in the same dose.

The scales arrived. Onesimus weighed each cup while the steward recorded the result. Four were indeed heavier, including the dented one. The discovery gave Valeria a sudden, petty desire to argue that Gaius's thumb had worn metal away rather than added to it.

"These four may go back," she said.

Onesimus marked the tablet. His relief was visible and therefore irritating.

"There are also the mules."

"At Tibur?"

"Yes. They were branded with the Caecilius mark after purchase."

"They were purchased with money from my portion."

"The steward there says the purchase was made on the master's instruction."

"My husband instructed many things. It did not make the money his."

Aelia leaned forward. "What does the farm account say?"

Onesimus produced another tablet. This one Valeria had not seen. The writing belonged to Felix—the farm bailiff at Tibur, not the child in Antonia's household whose name she knew only because her father had mentioned a boy carrying a basin like an offering. She disliked the distraction. Names wandered where they were not invited.

According to the bailiff, the mules had cost nine hundred sestertii. They had since consumed fodder, required shoeing, and pulled the press cart through an harvest. One had gone lame in February and recovered. The account did not state whose money had originally bought them. It was full of facts and notably absent where help was required.

"We can ask the dealer," Valeria said.

"He died in January."

"That was inconsiderate of him."

Onesimus's mouth moved, but he had served a grieving family long enough not to answer every sharpness. "His son keeps the yard."

"Then ask the son."

"We have. He remembers Gaius paying."

"With what?"

"Coin."

Her mother exhaled through her nose. Valeria wished she had eaten more at breakfast. Hunger made her precise in a way that sounded cruel.

"Let us move to the income before we starve the mules in argument," Aelia said.

The farm had produced oil worth, by the bailiff's estimate, eighteen thousand sestertii since Gaius's death. Marcus wanted the whole sum treated as estate income. Valeria's own copy of the account listed pressing, jars, transport, wages and repairs to a collapsed section of terrace wall. Six thousand four hundred had already been spent. Another amount remained in the hands of a merchant who had promised

payment when his ships' cargo was sold, a form of calendar understood mainly by merchants.

"Marcus believes expenses after the master's death should have been approved," Onesimus said.

"By Marcus?"

"By the estate."

"Olives do not wait for an estate to approve their ripening."

"The terrace wall—"

"Fell down. Also without approval."

Aelia said mildly, "You are enjoying this."

"I am not."

But she was, in the narrow way she had enjoyed anything since October: a problem was in front of her, and while she attended to it, other thoughts had to stand at the door. The cups could be weighed. The mules had eaten measurable fodder. Even the missing approval could be written as a disagreement and sent to someone else's house.

There was also the matter of a tenant named Nonia, whose husband had died two weeks before Gaius and whose rent Valeria had deferred until after the oil was sold. Marcus's list treated the arrears as money improperly given away.

"She has four children and a press beam that cracked in November," Valeria said.

"The estate cannot carry every misfortune within sight of its trees," Onesimus replied.

"It can carry one until the oil money arrives. If we seize her jars now, there will be nothing to collect from except our own satisfaction."

"Did Gaius agree to the deferral?"

"Gaius was dead. I agreed."

"That is the difficulty."

"No. The difficulty is that a dead man's household would prefer his widow's decision to be called generosity when it works and unauthorised when it costs."

Aelia had been following the figures. "How much?"

"One thousand two hundred, in money and oil together. She has paid three hundred since."

"Put the remaining nine hundred in the disputed column," Aelia said. "If the farm is Valeria's to administer until the accounts are settled, the deferral stands. If Marcus wishes to reverse it, he may explain to four children that an inventory required their hunger."

Onesimus wrote it down. Valeria knew that her mother's voice could make a position sound inevitable. It was useful, and a little frightening, to have it deployed on her side.

The linen came next: sheets used during Gaius's illness, some stained beyond redemption despite washing, others absorbed into the general stock. Onesimus wanted compensation for four missing pieces. Valeria remembered one torn into bandages, one burnt after the last night because the physician advised it, and two she could not account for at all.

"I will pay for two," she said.

"Marcus may say four."

"Marcus was not changing them at the third hour of the night. Let him say it to the women who were."

Her father entered as Onesimus was turning to the jewellery. Messalla had returned from Ostia the previous day with rain still in the seams of his cloak and very little to say beyond the fact that roofs did, after inspection, turn out to require roofs. He looked at the silver.

"Are we going to war over cups?"

"No," Valeria said. "We are returning four of them."

"That seems reasonable."

"It seemed reasonable before you arrived, too."

He accepted the correction with a slight inclination of his head. Since his return he had been listening in a way that made the household suspicious. Publius claimed their father had been replaced at Ostia by a more thoughtful man wearing the same face.

Onesimus cleared his throat. "The pearl earrings."

Valeria knew what was coming. Gaius had given them to her after their first harvest together, clumsily, in a box too large for them. His mother had admired them at dinner and said pearls suited young women because they forgave an uneven complexion. At the time Valeria had assumed this was merely an insult. Now Caecilia maintained that the earrings had belonged to her own mother and had only been lent.

"They were a gift," Valeria said.

"There is no entry."

"There seldom is when a husband gives his wife earrings in their bedroom."

Her father looked at the garden. Her mother looked at the tablet. Onesimus discovered an urgent need to straighten the scales.

"Were there witnesses?" Onesimus asked.

"My maid helped me put them on. Gaius's sister saw them that evening and asked whether he had robbed an oyster bed."

"He would have needed help," Publius said from the doorway.

No one had heard him come in. He was holding a plum and wearing the expression of a man who has entered for food and found jurisprudence.

"Leave," their mother said.

"I have only just—"

"Leave with the plum."

He went, injured, taking the plum.

Messalla said, "Could the earrings be returned as a gesture? It might make the rest easier."

Valeria looked at him. "Which of your possessions shall I return as a gesture?"

"That is not what I meant."

"It is what gestures usually mean. Someone else is generous with them."

The room became quiet enough for the kitchen chopping to resume its authority. Messalla did not insist. He picked up the dented cup, turned it once, and set it with the four identified for return.

"Your husband used that one," Aelia said.

"Yes."

"Do you want to ask whether—"

"No."

Valeria was surprised by the firmness of her own answer. The cup had seen Gaius alive. It had also been washed hundreds of times since. Keeping every object through which his hands had passed would convert the house into a store-room and herself into its clerk.

She dictated a proposal to the steward: the four heavier cups to be returned; the farm income to be accounted net of pressing, transport, wages and necessary repairs, with copies of both accounts exchanged; the mule dealer’s son to be asked again, in writing, what he remembered and what he did not; if the mules were held to be estate property, the estate must reckon the fodder and care since October rather than pretend they had lived on ancestry. The earrings remained hers. The statement of her maid and Gaius's sister could be provided.

Onesimus listened with increasing caution.

"Marcus may not accept."

"Then he may write a better proposal. I am not making him a gift of arithmetic."

"It would help if you met him."

"I have met him. He was my brother-in-law for three years."

"I meant about this."

Valeria's first answer was no. She could feel it, complete and satisfying. Then she remembered Marcus at Gaius's funeral, trying not to weep while his mother held his arm hard enough to leave marks. He had been twenty-three then and

suddenly responsible for a household that treated hesitation as an invitation to creditors.

"After he answers," she said. "If the answer suggests he has read the page."

Onesimus bowed. The cups for return were wrapped separately, but not yet sent. Nothing had been settled except a method for continuing not to settle it.

When he had gone, Aelia began putting the remaining cups back into their chest. Valeria took one and carried it to the sideboard instead.

"That will gather dust," her mother said.

"Then someone will wash it. It is a cup."

She set it where the evening light would catch it. It looked neither defiant nor consoling. It looked available for use.

• • •

Marcellus arrived for dinner carrying a jar of olives and an apology for bringing food to a house that had invited him to eat.

"My cook insists hers are better than anyone else's," he said. "If I leave the jar at home, she asks whether I was ashamed of her. If I bring it, I appear to doubt your kitchen. Age has not simplified diplomacy."

Aelia accepted the jar. "We will eat them and report a narrow victory to both sides."

He was fifty-four, tall without using the height aggressively, and walked with a slight unevenness from a fall years earlier. His hair was nearly white, but his face had not acquired the polished detachment Valeria associated with men who had survived public life by agreeing to become monuments. He greeted Messalla, then Publius, then her.

"Valeria."

"Marcellus."

"I am glad the dinner remained a dinner. I have eaten meals that turned into councils of war and the food suffered."

"My father has been instructed."

Messalla said, "I have been informed."

"There is a difference," Marcellus said. "I have children too."

They ate in the smaller dining room because Aelia said the large one encouraged speeches. The olives were indeed good, sharp with fennel. Publius ate six before noticing that everyone had noticed.

"They are small," he said.

"So are debts at first," his father replied.

The remark fell into an uncomfortable place. Publius reached for bread instead. Valeria saw Marcellus observe the exchange and choose not to decorate it.

Talk moved to the Tibur farm because Marcellus owned land farther along the same road and had opinions about drainage that were detailed enough to be useful. He asked Valeria whether the lower terrace flooded after heavy rain.

"Only where the wall fell."

"Then the wall was performing a service beyond standing."

"We have replaced it at disputed expense."

"Most of my best work has been disputed. By my neighbours, principally."

He did not ask for the details of the dispute. She found herself offering one anyway: the mules.

"Branded animals are a nuisance," he said. "A brand looks like certainty. It is only a scar with administration."

Messalla smiled despite himself. "You should have been an advocate."

"I lack the voice. And the patience to pretend my client's grandfather was relevant."

The meal continued with fish, young vegetables and a sauce Publius attempted to identify until Aelia told him that naming ingredients was not a substitute for conversation.

Marcellus asked about the new Forum, about Messalla's country house, about a public reading Publius had attended and pretended to have understood. He was good at allowing answers to finish. It was a minor talent which became rarer as men acquired importance.

Between courses the heat in the dining room drove them into the garden. Lamps had been set along the path, though the last daylight still lay across the upper leaves. The fountain basin had a crack that wasted a thin sheet of water onto the paving. Their gardener insisted it had been repaired; the wet stone offered a minority report.

Marcellus crouched—with some effort and no request for assistance—and put a finger to the seam.

"Your man has sealed the outside," he said. "Water is finding the old joint underneath."

"He will be delighted," Messalla said. "He regards advice as a form of weather: unpleasant, recurrent and not addressed to him personally."

"Then do not advise. Ask him whether the lower pipe was cleared. Gardeners can sometimes be led to their own conclusions if the path is not too obviously swept."

Valeria laughed. Marcellus stood, accepting Publius's offered arm without pretending he had not needed it. That, as much as his conversation, made an impression. Gaius, when ill, had apologised to furniture he used for support. Her father preferred to fall with dignity and blame the architect.

A young slave carrying a tray slipped on the wet paving and saved the cups by sacrificing a folded napkin to the fountain. He froze, looking at Aelia.

"Fish it out before it becomes an offering," she said.

Marcellus took one end of the tray while the boy retrieved the cloth. He did it without ceremony and returned the tray as if the incident had required no moral.

"You will spoil our standards," Messalla said.

"I have dropped enough official documents in unlikely places to respect a man who saves the cups."

They walked back under the portico as the lamps began to matter. A neighbour's musician was practising beyond the wall, repeating a phrase until it lost all resemblance to pleasure. Publius hummed the wrong ending each time. Aelia bore this by looking at the fountain as though water might eventually provide an answer.

After the tables were cleared, Aelia took Publius away to look at a chair that might or might not need repair. Messalla remained. Valeria appreciated that no one had staged an accidental privacy. Whatever this was, it would be conducted with witnesses and furniture.

Marcellus turned his cup in his hands. Unlike Gaius, he stopped when he noticed himself doing it.

"May I say plainly why I accepted your father's invitation?"

"You may say plainly why you issued half of it yourself."

"Fair. My house is quiet. I have a son with a family, a daughter who writes excellent letters and a staff capable of running a small province. None of them can provide companionship without turning it into either duty or management. I am not seeking an heir. I am not, I hope, seeking a nurse. I have property enough for my children and enough vanity left to prefer a wife who can tell me when I am being tedious."

"That is a substantial office."

"I have been told my drainage conversation requires supervision."

She smiled before she could make a policy of not smiling.

"Does your daughter approve?"

"No. She believes a second marriage insults her mother. My son approves in principle and reserves judgement about every particular woman, which is another form of opposition."

"And if they continue?"

"Then I will disappoint them with as much kindness as I can manage. They are adults. So, I am told, am I."

Messalla looked towards the garden, offering absence while remaining seated. Valeria wondered whether he had learnt that at Ostia or had always known how and simply needed rain to remind him.

"I do not know whether I want another marriage," she said.

"I am not asking tonight."

"My property is currently the subject of lists."

"Then I shall not ask tonight with a list."

"I may refuse later."

"Yes."

"You say that easily."

"It is easy because it is true before I want it to be otherwise. Remind me if I become less reasonable."

There was a confidence in him that could become entitlement, but she heard something else beneath it: a man accustomed to being refused by life in forms that did not permit negotiation. His wife had died four years earlier after an illness no one's influence could alter. Valeria's own widowhood was fresher. It did not create a bond by itself. Grief could make people selfish as readily as tender.

"Why me?" she asked.

Messalla shifted, perhaps preparing to rescue the conversation from candour. Marcellus answered first.

"Because at your cousin's house last winter you corrected a steward's addition without raising your voice, then noticed that the musician had not eaten. I admire competence when it does not require an audience. Also because you laughed at a joke your brother made before remembering you were supposed to be in mourning. It suggested you had not been entirely persuaded by the office."

Valeria felt heat rise in her face. She did not know whether she was pleased or exposed.

"You watch people closely."

"At my age, weddings, funerals and drains are the principal fields of study left."

Publius returned at that point, perhaps released by Aelia before the conversation could settle into a shape requiring announcement. He announced that the chair was not broken but had been built by a pessimist. Marcellus asked to see it and went with him willingly.

When he left later, he thanked Aelia for dinner and Valeria for enduring its purpose.

"My cousin opens her gardens in two weeks," he said. "There will be music, too many relations and a fountain of questionable taste. If your family comes, I would be glad to speak with you again. If not, I will understand that I have been answered."

"I will give you an answer more definite than absence."

"That is all I ask."

At the door, Messalla clasped his hand. Aelia instructed the porter to send the empty olive jar back filled with her own cook's plums in honey, a manoeuvre whose diplomatic meaning no one attempted to interpret. Valeria stood in the hall after the door closed, listening to Marcellus's uneven step fade along the street.

"Well?" Publius asked.

"Well what?"

"He only mentioned drainage twice."

"Three times. You were eating olives during one."

"Then it is practically a betrothal."

Aelia sent him to bed with the air of a woman who knew he would go to the kitchen instead.

• • •

In the morning her mother was trying to repair the clasp that had already been repaired once by being paid for.

It lay open on a cloth beside her accounts. Aelia held one side with a fingernail while a maid attempted to coax the little spring into place with a pin. The spring escaped and landed soundlessly in the wool of her dress.

"That is how fortunes go," Aelia said. "Not with theft. With small metal in soft places."

Valeria found the spring. "You want to discuss Marcellus."

"I want to discuss whether you slept."

"I slept."

"Then Marcellus."

The maid took the hint and withdrew. Aelia folded the cloth around the unrepaired clasp.

"He is a good man," she said.

"He may be. Good men still require feeding, listening to, and the rearrangement of one's house."

"He has a house."

"That is part of the rearrangement."

"You liked him."

Valeria sat in the chair opposite. From the courtyard came the regular tap of sweeping that woke her father and therefore, by extension, most of the household. "I liked dinner."

"That is not nothing."

"No. It is dinner."

Aelia put the clasp aside. She had a way of ending one task completely before allowing a conversation to become difficult.

"Your father would benefit from the connection," she said.

There it was. Valeria had been waiting for the sentence since the first mention of Marcellus's name.

"How much benefit?"

"Not money handed across a table. Confidence. A consular friend who does not treat a commercial embarrassment as the fall of the house. Perhaps influence with the other warehouse owners. Your father has returned from Ostia determined to

pay workmen and contradict Severus, which is admirable and may become expensive."

"And I am to make admiration affordable?"

"No. But I will not pretend your marriage has no consequences beyond whether you enjoy a man's conversation."

"My first marriage had consequences. I still had to live inside it every day."

"You loved Gaius."

"Eventually. At the beginning I loved that he did not shout and could recite only a reasonable amount of poetry."

Aelia's face softened. "He recited more after wine."

"He forgot the ends and invented them. Sometimes they improved."

They were quiet. The memory had entered without demanding control of the room, which was progress of a kind.

Valeria said, "Has Father asked you for money?"

"He has told me there may be a payment. He has not taken mine."

"That is not what I asked."

Aelia folded her hands. "Your uncle has asked me to stand behind part of a loan from Severus. I have not agreed. Your father's affairs have made me understand why a signature should not be treated as a family embrace."

Valeria took this in. Her uncle was charming at festivals and better at beginning ventures than at surviving their second year. The request explained some of her mother's attention to small springs and clasps.

"Does Father know you have told me?"

"He knows about the request. I am telling you because you are being asked to make an arrangement in a house where arrangements have become expensive."

"Then tell him this. I will meet Marcellus again. At his cousin's garden, and perhaps other places where people can behave like adults in public. There will be no betrothal this

spring. If there is ever a marriage, my property remains mine to pledge or not pledge, in writing, each time. It is not to be dropped into the family chest because Father has discovered warehouse roofs."

"That is reasonable."

"His children are to be told by him, not managed by me. I will not enter a house as an ambush."

Aelia nodded.

"And if I decide no, the answer is no without a second dinner designed to correct it."

"Yes."

"You agree too quickly."

"I have been married to your father for many years. I know the difference between influencing an outcome and choosing it."

From the doorway Messalla said, "I have been married to your mother for the same length of time and am still being educated."

Neither woman had heard him approach, which annoyed Valeria on principle. He carried no tablets. His hands looked unused to the condition.

"How much did you hear?" she asked.

"Enough to know I should knock inside my own house."

"You should."

He came in and sat, not at the head of the little table but on a stool near the window. Age had not made stools dangerous to his dignity, whatever Publius claimed.

"Marcellus will accept time," he said.

"Will he accept my property conditions?"

"They are not unusual in substance. They are unusual in being stated by the woman before the families have arranged the language."

"Then he may admire my novelty or withdraw."

"He might admire it."

Valeria looked at her father. There was a heaviness above his eyes that she remembered from childhood: the sign that he had entered a room with one speech and found it unsuitable.

"I will not sell you for a roof," he said.

"Roofs are important. Ask anyone at Ostia."

"Valeria."

"I know. You would never describe it that way."

"That is not the same as knowing whether I would do it."

The sentence startled all three of them. Aelia looked down at the folded cloth. Messalla seemed to consider withdrawing it and then, with visible effort, left it where it was.

"Then we understand each other," Valeria said.

"I hope so."

"I said understand. Do not turn it into a festival."

A brief laugh escaped him. It was not the careful laugh he used in public. She had missed that sound without having missed him in any simple way.

Later, she wrote her answer to Onesimus's proposal in her own hand before giving it to a scribe. The four heavy cups were wrapped and sealed, but would not be sent until Marcus replied. She added a line she had not dictated in the dining room: that Marcus might come himself when he had read the accounts, provided he did not bring his mother in the first instance. Caecilia could make an inventory sound like a blood feud.

For Marcellus, Aelia composed the family note accepting his cousin's invitation. Valeria read it twice. It contained gratitude, pleasure and no promises beyond attendance. She added nothing.

Publius found her when she went to put the letter with the outgoing tablets. He shut the door with a care that told her the errand was neither small nor honourable.

"If this concerns olives," she said, "confess to Mother."

"It concerns Decimus."

"Then confess to Father."

"He needs two thousand sestertii until his uncle's estate payment arrives."

"That sentence has supported more ruins than most aqueducts."

Publius's face tightened. "He is not ruined."

"Then he can borrow from someone who charges interest and does not love him."

"He has. That is the difficulty."

Valeria put the letter down. "How much have you promised?"

"Nothing."

"Publius."

"I told him I would ask whether you might help. I have not signed anything."

It was probably true. It was also the closest he could come to a promise while retaining the technical purity of his hands.

"No," she said.

"You have money from the farm."

"I have accounts, claims, expenses and other people's descriptions of money. Even if I had two thousand sitting in a box, I would not lend it secretly so that you can be generous and Decimus can be surprised by mathematics."

"He would repay you."

"Then let him ask me, with his uncle's payment described by someone who has seen it. And let Father hear."

"Father dislikes him."

"Father dislikes paying for him. There is a distinction, though I admit it narrows at close range."

Publius picked up the stylus from her table and put it down again. At nineteen he still believed a friend in trouble constituted a command from the gods. She remembered believing something similar at his age, though her commands had more often involved keeping confidences than opening strongboxes.

"If I do nothing—"

"You will feel disloyal. That is not the same as being it. Tell Decimus you asked. Tell him I refused. If he calls that betrayal, he has told you what your friendship was for."

He wanted to argue. Instead he looked at the sealed cups on the side table.

"Is that what being a widow teaches? Everyone has a price for affection?"

"No. It teaches that affection should not be asked to sign in the dark."

He left without slamming the door, which in Publius was near enough to philosophical acceptance. Valeria gave the letter to the porter herself, so that it would not wait among tablets for less complicated business.

That evening she took wine in the cup she had placed on the sideboard. It was ordinary wine, watered because the day had been warm. She drank while Publius tried to teach a household dog to ignore dropped food, a lesson at which teacher and pupil were equally unsuccessful. Her father spoke to Herennius in the next room about a timber tally and a carter whose name had finally been supplied in a form nobody could read with confidence. Her mother sent for the unrepaired clasp and then forgot why.

The cup did not solve widowhood. It held wine. For the moment, competence that modest was enough.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Small Hours

The scar on Nysa's lip had become a pale interruption rather than a wound. In the steam of the baths it showed when she turned towards the window, vanished when she laughed, and returned as soon as her face settled.

"You keep looking at it," she said.

"I am looking to see whether I am still looking at it."

"That sounds like the sort of sentence men pay you to answer."

Antonia lowered herself another step into the warm pool. The water took her weight with a generosity her knees had begun to discuss privately. Around them women moved between basins, oil flasks and benches with the unobserved competence of a place designed, for these hours, without an audience. A child no older than Felix was being washed by an older sister and objecting to the moral character of soap-root. Two prosperous freedwomen debated the price of a hairdresser as if arranging a military alliance.

Nysa sat on the submerged step with water at her waist. Her hair was pinned plainly. Without the evening paint she looked younger and more tired.

"Does it hurt?" Antonia asked.

"When I eat anything sour. When I smile too widely at a man who has not earned it. It is becoming an adviser."

"An expensive one."

"Most are."

A bath attendant brought oil and strigils. Antonia dismissed her with payment for both; she wanted no hands that

afternoon except her own. Nysa worked oil into her shoulders. She had the body of a woman who looked after it because other people were careless with it.

"I saw the shop again," she said.

"Claudia's?"

"Claudia Prima. She is offering me a third share for sixteen thousand. That includes stock, the counter, the lease until next spring and her late husband's opinion painted above the door, which she says cannot be removed because customers trust it."

"How much do you have?"

"Nine thousand two hundred. A little more if a man in Antium pays what he owes before he remembers that gratitude is also a currency."

"You need nearly seven thousand."

"And a guarantor for the lease. Claudia trusts my nose for oils and my judgement of women who pretend they have come in for a friend. The landlord trusts neither sex unaccompanied by property."

Antonia scraped oil and dust from her forearm. "I could guarantee it."

"Yes."

"You say that as if it were an accusation."

"It is an answer."

"Would you accept?"

Nysa moved deeper into the water. The child being washed gave a triumphant shriek and escaped three steps before recapture.

"If I owe you for the shop," Nysa said, "every evening I am free will have a small room in your house where it waits to be called back."

"I would not call it."

"You might not need to. I would hear it."

Antonia understood. That did not make the understanding welcome. She had built her safety by converting obligations

into things that could be named, priced and survived. She had less practice in respecting obligations that existed because they had not been accepted.

"What will Claudia do if you cannot raise it?"

"Take a perfumer's nephew. He has money and an itch behind one ear that makes customers leave before buying. Claudia says the shop can survive him if he is kept among the jars. She would rather have me, but rather is not a bank."

"Have the documents examined."

"I have an appointment with a man who does accounts for two bakers and a dealer in Spanish oil. He is not Crispus."

"I was not going to suggest Crispus."

"You were going to suggest someone who would report to you at dinner."

Antonia looked at her. "Am I so consistent?"

"Only in the belief that care and supervision are cousins."

From the hotter room came a burst of laughter. A woman emerged red-faced and announced to no one in particular that she had been boiled into honesty. Nysa smiled carefully, mindful of the scar.

"Two engagements have been cancelled," she said.

"Because of Varro?"

"One host said his wife had heard there was an unpleasantness. The other said the dinner would be smaller than expected. Both may be lying. Neither owes me a better reason."

"I can ask—"

"No."

"You have not heard what I can ask."

"I have heard the shape of it. If you restore me by influence, I return with your name tied around my ankle."

Antonia let the strigil rest against the pool edge. She disliked being refused help almost as much as she disliked needing it. The resemblance did not improve her temper.

"Would you come back for one evening next week?" she asked. "Not Varro. He will not be there. A merchant from Narbo and his partners. Music, dinner, no private arrangement unless you choose it."

"Is the merchant tiresome?"

"He is rich, recently widowed and believes grief has made him profound."

"That is worse than tiresome. How much?"

They negotiated with an ease that restored something between them. Nysa asked for her fee in advance, a carriage home paid separately, and the right to leave after the second course if the widower began reciting his wife's virtues as an invitation. Antonia agreed to the fee and carriage, refused a contractual limit on conversation, and promised to seat Sabina between Nysa and any man who brought a prepared speech about loss.

"Poor Sabina," Nysa said.

"Sabina enjoys being thought profound by association."

A woman with hennaed feet lowered herself into the pool nearby, sighing at the heat. The conversation paused for her arrival and resumed at a lower volume.

"If the shop fails," Antonia said, "you will have spent your savings on jars."

"If I stay as I am, I will spend my face on dinners."

"There are other trades."

"Name one that pays a woman quickly for being ornamental and then lets her keep the skill when she is no longer ornamental."

"Marriage, if she chooses the right corpse."

Nysa laughed and immediately touched her lip.

"Your sympathy has recovered," she said.

"I am trying to keep it from purchasing things."

They left the pool for the cool room. An attendant wrapped them in linen. Nysa's shoulders carried faint marks from massage and sun; Antonia's own body in the polished bronze

mirror looked serviceable, altered, not yet reconciled to being looked at by its owner without commercial assessment.

"Do you ever miss wanting to be wanted?" Nysa asked.

"I miss wanting without first considering the cost of the room."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the answer I have at forty-two."

Nysa fastened her dress. The simplicity of the gesture made Antonia aware of how little of their conversation had belonged to the house. No guest had required rescuing. No fee had made candour part of a performance.

"Come and see the shop," Nysa said suddenly. "Not to guarantee it. To tell me whether the counter is too near the door and whether Claudia's husband's painted opinion can be trusted."

"When?"

"Now. It is two streets from here, and Claudia will pretend she was not expecting us."

"My warehouses seldom ask permission. Lead on."

Outside, the street was bright after the dim rooms. A seller of roasted beans had set his tray where bathers emerged hungry and susceptible. Antonia bought two portions. Nysa ate hers slowly on the side of her mouth away from the scar and pretended not to notice Antonia noticing.

Claudia's shop occupied the front room of a building whose upper floor leaned very slightly towards the baths, as though listening for gossip. The painted sign showed a woman with improbably abundant hair and the words, in faded red, FINE OILS — HONEST MEASURE. Beneath it someone had scratched a much smaller opinion about the measure.

"You see?" Nysa said. "The husband's judgement above the door."

"The scratch may be more recent market research."

Inside, the air was dense with iris root, rose, bitter almond and the green smell of unripe olives. Jars stood in graduated

sizes. A counter separated customers from a back bench where Claudia Prima was decanting oil through a funnel with the concentration of a priestess and the sleeves of a woman who had ruined better dresses by optimism.

She was perhaps fifty, broad-hipped, with grey hair worn in a practical knot and gold earrings that contradicted any claim of poverty.

"I was not expecting you," she said.

"You have set out three cups," Nysa replied.

"One is for tasting. Antonia, sit where the floor is dry. If there is a dry place."

A customer entered while they talked, a young woman accompanied by an older slave who carried the money and most of the visible scepticism. The customer wanted something for a husband who disliked perfume but expected her to smell as if she had invented spring. Claudia listened, asked what he ate, whether he worked near animals, and whether the marriage was new. She sold a small jar rather than a large one and told the woman to return when she knew if he noticed.

"That is poor selling," Antonia said when the door closed.

"It is excellent selling. She will come back with two friends and a grievance against the husband. We sell grievances in several sizes."

Nysa moved behind the counter without asking and corrected the position of a tray of hairpins. She knew where the spatulas were. Watching her, Antonia felt an unfamiliar pang that had nothing to do with losing a courtesan. She had seen Nysa arrange men around a dining room with the same instinct, but there the arrangement vanished when the guests went home. Here, a jar returned to its place stayed returned.

Claudia produced the lease summary. The landlord wanted a guarantor with urban property and the first payment before the Kalends. The shop took money reliably from bath customers, less reliably in winter. A dealer in Spanish oil

owed Claudia for returned stock. Her late husband's brother claimed a share of the counter because he had once paid a carpenter while drunk and now remembered the act as investment.

"Every business has one," Claudia said. "Mine is related to me by marriage and to carpentry by hallucination."

"Would you let Nysa pay in two parts?" Antonia asked.

"I would let Nysa do many things. The landlord has a narrower imagination."

"And if the perfumer's nephew buys the share?"

Claudia wiped the funnel. "Then I will put him in the back with the jars and teach customers to shout their orders through the curtain."

A second customer, a man buying oil for his mother, recognised Antonia and spent so long proving he had never visited her house that he bought the most expensive jar. Claudia thanked him without revealing whether the price was for oil or absolution.

When he had gone, Nysa said, "This is what I want you to see. It is not respectable in the way wives mean it. It is work where a woman can be known by name and still decide what her hands are for."

Antonia examined the counter. It was too near the door; customers entering in wet weather would bring the street directly to the jars. A step had worn smooth where the floor sloped. But light fell across the front bench, the back room was dry, and the courtyard well was shared with only two other tenants. She said so, in order, and did not offer to guarantee the lease.

Claudia poured watered wine into the third cup that had definitely not been set out for tasting.

"To honest measure," she said.

Nysa drank from the unscarred side of her mouth. "And to men who pay in Antium."

• • •

Felix's ear began to hurt after midnight.

Damaris brought him to the little room beside Antonia's because the passage there was warmer and because, when he was ill, he wanted his mother near and Antonia's lamp visible through the doorway. He lay with his head against Damaris's shoulder, hot and furious at a pain he could neither reach nor blame convincingly on anyone.

"It is inside," he said. "Something is knocking."

"Then we shall not answer," Damaris told him.

Antonia sent Meroe to bed after the second hour. The seamstress protested until Damaris said her shoulder would make them three invalids by morning. Crispus appeared once with warmed oil, announced that he knew nothing about ears except that his own were used against him by accountants, and was sent away with instructions to sleep where the morning merchants would find him conscious.

The physician who attended the house lived two streets away. Antonia had him fetched not because Felix seemed in danger, but because the ability to summon help was one of the uses of money she did not intend to apologise for. He arrived smelling of night air, looked into the ear, felt the boy's neck, asked what he had eaten, and prescribed warmth, diluted wine no stronger than a rumour, and observation. He also advised against tying the loose tooth to a door, a practice Felix had been considering as a distraction.

"Not tonight," the physician said. "One pain at a time is a household rule worth keeping."

After he left, Felix dozed in pieces. Each waking began with a cry shortened by Damaris's hand at his back. Antonia sat in the doorway with accounts she did not read. The house in the small hours had a different population: the night porter coughing by the gate, the baker's boy asleep on a bench near

the ovens, Thaleia somewhere practising so softly that the notes could have been remembered rather than played.

"You should rest," Damaris said.

"So should you."

"One of us can be ordered."

"Then I am ordering myself. It preserves the dignity of the establishment."

Felix woke and demanded water. Antonia held the cup while Damaris lifted him. His hair was damp. He drank, complained that the water tasted of lamp, and asked whether Ostia still had his pebble.

"No," Damaris said. "It came back."

"Did the road mind?"

"The road sent rain after it."

He considered this evidence of powerful magic and fell asleep with the pebble in his fist.

Antonia looked at Damaris over the child's head. The woman's face had the emptied stillness of someone who had stopped expecting rest to arrive in a usable form.

"Crispus has a day," Antonia said quietly. "For the clerk. The morning after tomorrow. His name is Hermas. He prepares papers for an advocate named Papirius."

Damaris did not move, for Felix's breathing was balanced against her shoulder.

"Did Crispus see him?"

"He saw the advocate's door slave and then Hermas himself. It cost a basket of last year's wine and the promise that we would not arrive expecting a miracle before breakfast."

"Where?"

"Near the Forum. You will speak first. I will be there because the law may require my ugliest furniture: my ownership."

A small sound escaped Damaris. It might have become laughter in daylight.

"Thank you."

"Do not thank me for a door. We do not know what is behind it."

"I can thank you for telling me before you were rested enough to make it sound better."

The lamp needed trimming. Antonia rose, and Felix stirred but did not wake. She cut the blackened wick with the little shears kept by the bed. The flame steadied.

When she was young, she had believed tenderness required a special occasion or an exceptional person. The years had revised her. It was mostly staying up when sleep was available, heating oil no one would remember, and not converting another person's helplessness into an invitation to speak about oneself. She was not consistently good at it. That night she could at least refrain from giving Damaris advice about hope.

Felix woke again towards the end of the night and demanded a song, not because he expected to sleep but because wakefulness without entertainment seemed a failure of household management. Damaris began one under her breath, a nonsense song about a goat elected to public office. Halfway through the second verse Thaleia appeared in the doorway with her instrument wrapped in cloth.

"I heard him," she said.

"You were supposed to be asleep," Antonia told her.

"So was everyone. The house has poor discipline after midnight."

Thaleia sat on the floor where the lamplight did not fall directly on her face and played the tune properly, slowing it until the goat's political career became almost dignified. Felix watched her fingers. Twice his eyes closed. Twice a fresh knock of pain opened them. On the third, he slept with his mouth open and his hand still raised as if about to make a point in debate.

Thaleia lowered the instrument. "He did that when he was four. Fell asleep accusing the cook."

"The cook had taken his fig," Damaris said.

"A serious charge."

Antonia sent her back to bed with the remains of the warmed wine. Thaleia went, but at the door she looked at Damaris and said, "Hermas. Papirius. I heard. I hope the man's door opens inward."

Damaris waited until her steps had gone.

"What if he says I can be freed and Felix cannot?"

The question arrived without hostility, which made it harder.

"Then we ask what can be done, in what order, and at what cost."

"And if every answer requires waiting until he is older?"

"Then I will not free you away from him and call it a completed promise."

"You could sell him to someone who—" Damaris stopped. The sentence had entered a territory neither of them wanted to map aloud.

"No," Antonia said.

"You did not hear it."

"I heard enough."

Felix shifted. Damaris adjusted the cloth at his ear. In the kitchen below, someone moved a bench with the care of a person trying not to advertise being awake before their assigned suffering.

Damaris said, "When you were freed, did it feel different the next morning?"

Antonia had been asked this before, usually by people who wanted a story with a clean sunrise. She considered the benefit of giving Damaris one and rejected it.

"I woke in the same room. My patron's steward knocked and asked whether I intended to spend liberty in bed. I was furious that he could still ask. Then I got up because there

was work. For weeks I kept waiting for a feeling to catch up with the document."

"Did it?"

"In pieces. The first time I refused a guest without inventing an illness. The first time I kept money in a box with my name on the key tag. Other pieces never arrived."

Damaris looked down at Felix. "I do not want pieces."

"No. But pieces may be what can be carried through a door."

Near dawn, Felix's ear discharged a little fluid and the pain lessened with the suddenness of a guest leaving before the bill. The physician was sent word not to return unless fever rose. Damaris slept at last in the chair with Felix across her lap, her head tipped against the wall. Antonia covered them both with a blanket and stood for a moment aware that care performed inside ownership did not cancel the ownership. It made the contradiction warmer, not smaller.

She went down to the account room because sleep had missed its opportunity.

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Crispus was already there, wearing the woollen cap and an expression that suggested dawn had personally misled him.

"You look," he said, "like a woman whose accounts have been awake all night biting her."

"Felix's ear."

"Better?"

"For now. What is that?"

He had laid out three rolls and a tablet in a row. She recognised the house copy of the wage receipt from Ostia, Herennius's careful writing reproduced by Crispus with the original marks copied as marks, not improved into signatures. Beside it was the warehouse statement Severus's clerk had delivered. Beside that, older and more fragile, a partnership

memorandum from the year Antonia had bought additional vineyard shares.

"I have been looking for the repair reserve," Crispus said.

"I assumed it had gone on the roofs that are leaking."

"That would require it to have existed."

He turned the older memorandum towards her. At the bottom was her seal and, in his own hand from ten years earlier, a note: reserve deferred one year at owner's instruction; distribution applied to vineyard purchase; replenish from vintage proceeds.

Antonia remembered the vineyard. It had seemed a respectable, sunlit asset after too many evenings spent listening to men describe pleasure as if it were an estate they had inherited. The vintage had been good. The proceeds had repaired a retaining wall, replaced presses and paid a debt Antonia Secunda's executor had presented with the confidence of a man reading weather.

"One year," she said.

"Yes. The difficulty is in the following page."

There was no following page in the memorandum. There were statements in which the reserve appeared as a heading without accumulation, distributions recorded neatly beneath it. She had received money year after year. At first she had asked Crispus whether repairs were covered. He had pointed to Hilarus's assurances. Then she had stopped asking because the income arrived and other things required the particular ferocity of her attention: a furnace, a lawsuit over a neighbouring wall, a patron's funeral, a singer's voice breaking at the wrong age.

"You might have reminded me," she said.

"I did. Twice. Once you were preparing for a dinner and told me to put it with the quarterly papers. Once you said Hilarus had written that the roofs would serve."

"That was last autumn."

"The second time was three years ago. Last autumn you reminded yourself, which is less reliable."

Antonia sat. The chair was too low; Crispus liked visitors at a disadvantage when figures were on the table.

"How much should there have been?"

"If the original proportion had been held from every distribution, a little over twenty-two thousand. Not enough for every claim Severus is making. Enough that timber would not have had to be miraculously exchanged into absence."

"Do not be witty with my money."

"It is not only yours. Messalla's share of the missing reserve is larger. The other owners took theirs. The practice became ordinary because everyone liked income better than roofs."

"Did you?"

"I like being paid. Accountants also prefer roofs in theory."

She looked at the wage receipt. Four hundred sestertii had acquired a satisfying solidity in retrospect. Men paid. Marks on a sheet. Her own one hundred and sixty-four advanced with the right words. It did not place her outside the longer failure.

"Severus knew," she said.

"Probably. Lenders notice when owners spend what should have been kept. It makes them necessary."

"And Hilarus?"

"Hilarus told each of you what you had previously rewarded him for telling you."

That was close enough to her own business to hurt. Antonia had made a fortune by letting guests believe their preferences were spontaneous. She had less right than most to be scandalised by a manager who studied his audience.

The porter knocked before Antonia could decide whether anger at herself was a sufficient breakfast. Severus's clerk waited in the hall with a sealed proposal and the polished

patience of a man who had been told not to remain for an answer.

Antonia had him remain.

He was young, clean-shaven, and carried his tablets against his chest like a shield. The proposal offered to consolidate the warehouse advances into a single acknowledgement of one hundred and sixty-eight thousand sestertii, payable in instalments, with all owners bound for the whole if any defaulted. In exchange, Severus would complete the roof work immediately and reduce the interest by an amount the document called generous without troubling to state its former size.

"Who wrote 'generous'?" Antonia asked.

The clerk blinked. "It is a formal expression."

"So is 'beloved'. I do not sign that at the bottom of accounts."

Crispus took the sheet. "Where are the vouchers for wages?"

"They are in preparation at Ostia."

"Timber?"

"The manager has been instructed."

"Cartage? Tolls? Storage elsewhere?"

The clerk looked towards the door, perhaps seeking the part of the proposal that had promised he would not stay.

"My principal believes a comprehensive settlement will save expense," he said.

"Your principal is often believed. Does he have Hilarus's authority to include wages that have now been paid directly?"

The young man glanced at the copy of the wage receipt. Severus had heard, then. Not necessarily the details, but enough to know that an inspection had produced witnesses.

"Any sums properly discharged can be credited."

"Properly is doing a great deal of labour there," Crispus said.

Antonia asked whether the other owners had signed. One executor had indicated willingness. The other family was considering. Messalla had not answered. This information was offered as pressure and received as a warning against becoming the first name that made the rest look inevitable.

"Tell Severus," she said, "that I will examine itemised advances with dates, recipients and authority. I will not convert uncertainty into my signature because he has had it copied beautifully."

"He hopes to begin the roofs before more rain."

"So do the roofs. Let him send a builder's estimate separately from his loan."

The clerk bowed, relieved to be given a message short enough to survive delivery. At the door he paused.

"He also asked me to say that the offer for your share remains open."

"For how long?"

"Until the fifteenth."

"How tender of him to marry commerce to a calendar."

After the clerk left, Crispus set the proposal beside the old memorandum. The neat new hand and Antonia's faded seal looked at one another across ten years of distributions.

"He timed that well," Crispus said.

"He usually does."

"You could still sign."

"So could you sign away the house and blame the ink. We are full of capacities."

She took a fresh sheet.

"What are you doing?" Crispus asked.

"Writing to Messalla."

"Before food?"

"Before I become rested enough to make it sound better."

She wrote that she had found her own instruction deferring the reserve and no evidence that she had required its restoration. She proposed that, before the fifteenth of May,

they distinguish three things which Severus's statement preferred as one: wages actually earned, necessary repairs actually performed or still required, and advances whose authority remained disputed. Her share of any established repair obligation she would meet, but she would not sign a general acknowledgement because shame had made her prompt. She also intended to place her next warehouse distribution—if the owners' instruction against distributions held, there would be none—towards sound roofs. The sentence dissatisfied her. She struck it out and wrote that she would set aside money from the vineyard account as her repair contribution, to be released against witnessed work.

Crispus read over her shoulder. "You have not said how much."

"Because I do not yet know what work costs when the timber stays in the building."

"You could sell the emerald pin."

"I could sell your cap and achieve less."

"It has sentimental value."

"So has the pin. I am keeping both until sentiment becomes less liquid than roofs."

She sealed the letter and gave it to a messenger who had come for the market list. He was to take it to Messalla's house after delivering Crispus's instructions to a wine merchant. Ordinary errands could carry difficult news if arranged in the correct order.

"Now the box," she said.

Crispus looked up. "Which box?"

"The one you are about to label so that I cannot pretend it is for something else. Put five thousand from the vineyard receipts into it. Roofs, witnessed work only. Not interest. Not Hilarus's cartage. Not an emergency in my dining room."

"Five thousand will not rebuild the west side."

"No. It will prevent me from saying I intended to begin."

He fetched the smaller strongbox, the one with a key that stuck unless turned with excessive confidence. Together they counted the money in silver and marked the amount on a fresh tablet. Crispus wrote ROOFS in letters large enough to accuse her from across the room.

"The new lamp for the garden room?" he asked.

"Postponed."

"The merchant from Narbo will think the old one charmingly dim."

"He can bring his own profundity."

"And the emerald pin?"

Antonia touched the place on her dress where it would sit that evening. She was not wearing it. "Still mine. Do not make a parable of one box."

"I would not dare. Parables are your department, usually after the subject has left the room."

He locked the box. The key stuck, then turned. Five thousand sestertii made very little sound behind wood and iron, which was perhaps why money preferred documents. Documents could rustle importantly while accomplishing nothing.

Upstairs, Felix was awake and demanding bread with the authority of a small emperor restored by public acclamation. Damaris had washed the side of his face and put the pebble back into her pouch. She looked at Antonia.

"Hermas," she said. "The morning after tomorrow."

"You remember."

"I remember things said over sleeping children."

Antonia sat on the edge of the bed because there was nowhere else that did not involve standing while exhausted. Felix offered her a piece of his bread, generously, from the end he had already chewed.

"No," she said. "Keep your strength."

He ate it himself, satisfied that generosity had been witnessed.

Damaris began listing the morning's work from habit: market, linen, the gardener's bill, a musician who had not been paid because the last dinner had ended in an argument about fish. Antonia took the tablet from her.

"Sleep until the second hour," she said. "Meroe can tell the gardener to become interesting later."

"And the market?"

"I have been known to buy vegetables without a steward standing beside me looking virtuous."

Damaris handed over the keys, but only after Felix had solemnly touched each one to make sure none had been lost during the night.

The day gathered outside: water carriers, voices in the street, the first guest's messenger arriving hours too early with a question about fish. Antonia's letter was somewhere between a wine merchant and the Palatine. She could not call it back now, which was perhaps why she had sent it before breakfast.

CHAPTER SIX

Stone and Bread

Antonia's letter reached the Palatine smelling faintly of wine.

The messenger apologised before Messalla had broken the seal. He had delivered instructions to a wine merchant first, as ordered; a jar had been opened to settle a dispute over sediment; no one had spilt anything on the letter, but the shop's atmosphere had ambitions. Messalla dismissed him with a coin and took the letter into the room where Herennius kept the estate correspondence.

Her handwriting had not been softened by a scribe. It leaned hard into the page.

She had found her own seal on the instruction deferring the warehouse reserve. She had not required its restoration. She proposed separating wages, necessary work and disputed advances before signing anything in a fit of shame. She had set money aside for witnessed repairs.

Messalla read it twice. On the second reading, the sentence about shame seemed less addressed to him than included for his instruction.

"Well?" Herennius asked.

"She is more candid than either of us."

"That may be because she wrote before breakfast."

"Or because she expects Severus to discover it and prefers her own wording."

Herennius did not dispute the less generous interpretation. He laid out the household's Ostia papers: the partnership authority, Severus's statement, the marked transcription of Vibius's letter, the wage receipt from the inspection. Since

their return from Ostia, a timber tally had arrived in handwriting so compressed that three people had produced four readings of the carter's name.

"Did my father ever ask about a reserve?" Messalla asked.

"Your father regarded reserves as money that had not yet been persuaded."

"And I?"

"You regarded Hilarus's annual assurance as an answer."

Messalla looked at him. Advancement in a household could teach a man the exact distance between honesty and dismissal. Herennius had begun reducing that distance.

From a drawer Messalla took the estate account for the previous autumn. There was the warehouse distribution, entered as income. Below: repairs to the retaining wall above the tenants' yard at the Tibur estate, purchase of two oxen, a contribution towards the rebuilding of a family tomb. Each item defensible. Together, a biography of a man who had used money from a leaking roof to mend a different piece of property and called the transfer prudence.

Aelia came in carrying a basket of early roses. She set it down when she saw the letter.

"From Antonia?"

"Yes."

"Has she discovered that you are both innocent and Severus is a villain in a cloak?"

"She has discovered that she is not innocent."

Aelia read the letter standing. She did not sit in Herennius's chair, though it was empty, perhaps because women were expected to make financial concern look temporary even in their own houses.

"She proposes not signing," she said.

"Nor do I."

"Then what will you pay on the fifteenth?"

"Nothing until I know what the payment is for."

"Severus may not consider your education a recognised currency."

Messalla took the letter back. "I am going to Tibur tomorrow."

"To escape Severus?"

"There is a wall, a cistern, tenants asking for grain, and a town deputation has found Agathopus easier to approach than me. If I am to be ruined by roofs, I should at least inspect my own masonry."

His wife selected a rose with a damaged outer petal and removed it.

"Take enough money to pay the men who have finished work."

"Agathopus says the final payment can wait until after the hay."

"Agathopus is a freedman who believes patience in other people reflects well on his management. Ask the masons."

"I intend to."

"Then also intend to listen."

She left the basket. The room filled with rose scent, an unhelpful fragrance for a man trying to reduce all obligations to columns.

Messalla wrote his reply before the clients arrived. He acknowledged that the distributions had entered his accounts without inquiry; part of the last one had paid for work on his own estate wall. He accepted Antonia's separation of wages, necessary repairs and disputed authority. He proposed that they meet Severus together before the fifteenth, with both accountants, and require Hilarus to attend rather than send statements by weather. He did not offer absolution. She had not requested it in a form he could supply.

He sealed the reply himself. Herennius watched the wax cool.

"Shall I take it?" the manager asked.

"No. Send the boy who carries invitations. Let it look like ordinary correspondence."

"It is ordinary correspondence. Two owners discussing debts."

Messalla put the seal back into its box. "Then it should have no difficulty behaving like it."

The morning clients were already gathering. He dealt with them from the edge of his thoughts: a recommendation for a clerk whose previous patron had died at an inconvenient stage in both their careers; a petition about a boundary ditch; a man who wanted the loan of his name for a warehouse licence and became offended when asked what the warehouse contained. Messalla refused the last with a politeness he hoped would survive repetition.

Between callers Herennius put Agathopus's latest estate letter in front of him. It was written in the steward's sprawling hand, each difficulty cushioned by two successes. The lower wall was sound but unfinished. The masons had begun to ask whether they would be paid before the town fountain contract. Tenants needed grain. A cistern channel was leaking into a storeroom. Two vines had been stolen—not grapes, Agathopus specified, whole rooted vines, an act requiring either confidence or a cart. The town council requested an answer about the fountain before their next meeting.

"You told me the wall was repaired," Messalla said.

"I repeated Agathopus."

"Then we have both been practising literature."

He found Aelia in the garden, directing the removal of spent roses. She wore an old dress for the task and gloves that had once belonged to her brother. Publius was helping by putting every cut stem into the wrong basket.

"If you are going to Tibur," she said to Messalla, "do not return saying everyone is content because no one raised his voice."

"Do tenants usually raise their voices to me?"

"No. They lie in a lower register."

Publius looked up from the basket. "May I come?"

"Do you want to?" his father asked.

"I want to see whether country people really rise with the sun or merely claim to have met it."

"Then stay in Rome and rise with it here. It will be a useful introduction."

"Aelia, am I being given an education?"

"Continuously. Hold the basket still."

Messalla waited until Publius had carried the stems away, still to the wrong place, before saying, "Agathopus asks for decisions, not specifically money."

"Then he has become a philosopher since winter."

"I can take enough cash for the masons and still meet a reasonable first claim from Severus."

"Reasonable is doing the work of several unknown sums."

"I know."

Aelia stripped a thorn from her glove. "When I married you, estates seemed to produce money as trees produce leaves. No one explained that half the leaves were owed to the man who had pruned the trees."

"Would it have altered your answer?"

"I might have asked better questions."

"That is becoming a family speciality."

She almost smiled. "Pay earned wages before you preserve money for disputed ones. It is not a complete philosophy, but it can be carried in one hand."

He had not come for advice. He had come to tell her of the journey after it had effectively been decided. That she supplied advice anyway was among the terms on which their marriage had survived.

That night he checked the travelling cash himself: twelve thousand was too round a figure once Herennius had removed money for road expenses and added a small amount received

from a tenant in Rome. Messalla put three thousand six hundred into a separate purse for the masons, looked at it, and then—because Severus had a talent for entering rooms he had not been invited into—returned the purse to the general box without tying its label.

Herennius found him still beside the open box.

"The inventory from my father's tomb repairs," Messalla said. "Is it with the estate papers?"

"Why?"

"Antonia used her distribution for a vineyard. I want to know what worthy object consumed mine."

The manager brought a bundle whose tie broke when lifted. Inside were masons' receipts for the family tomb, a payment to a letter-cutter, and a note in Messalla's own hand postponing an inscription because the proposed list of offices had omitted one of which his father was proud. The old man had been dead when the note was written. Messalla had nevertheless acted as if correction might reach him through marble.

"Did I approve all this?" he asked.

"You approved the total and questioned the lettering."

"A proper distribution of my talents."

Herennius retied the bundle with new cord. "Shall I tell Antonia that?"

"No. She has enough of my character for one correspondence."

Aelia looked in on her way to bed. She saw the open cash box and the unlabelled purse.

"Take something for the road servants as well," she said. "Not from the masons' money."

Messalla added a smaller purse and this time tied both labels. It was a minor victory over intention. He spoilt it before sleeping by wondering whether Severus would regard a labelled purse as morally unavailable. Severus would not. That was presumably why men borrowed from him.

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The Tibur road carried them out of the city in morning light already warm enough to promise inconvenience. Messalla rode with Herennius and two servants; a mule carried the cash box, clothing and enough documents to sink a modest boat. By the time the road began to climb, Rome had become a pale interruption behind them.

His estate lay below the town, where the land stepped down in terraces towards the river. Olive trees gave the slopes their grey-green patience. Vines climbed poles in rows. The villa house, built by his grandfather with more regard for view than drainage, looked prosperous from a distance and increasingly argumentative as they approached.

Agathopus met them at the gate. He was a freedman of sixty with a beard cut close to demonstrate independence from fashion and a habit of beginning every report with what had gone well. The oxen were well. The lower vines were well. The steward's granddaughter had recovered from a fever. The wall was, by the time he reached it in the sequence, a situation requiring decision.

"You said it was repaired," Messalla remarked.

"The dangerous section was taken down and rebuilt. The upper section requires completion before the winter rains. There is a difference between repaired and finished."

"There is also a difference in how the words affect an account."

Agathopus led them behind the house. The retaining wall supported a terrace planted with young fig trees. Below it, tenants kept tools, baskets and a goat with an expression of legal entitlement. New stone formed the lower half of the wall. Above it, the older work bulged slightly outward. Water had darkened the mortar. A wooden prop leaned where confidence ought to have been.

Dionysius, the lead mason, stood with a plumb line in one hand. He was a broad man of perhaps forty-five, his forearms powdered white with stone dust. Three men worked behind him sorting blocks. A fourth was absent.

"How long?" Messalla asked.

"To finish properly? Eight days if the stone is here and the lime arrives. Less if you want it standing for your lifetime only."

"My lifetime is not an engineering unit I wish to test."

Dionysius let the line fall. It showed what the eye suspected.

"The final payment for the lower section is due," he said. "Three thousand six hundred. Then there is the new work."

Agathopus answered before Messalla could. "It was agreed the balance would be settled after the hay."

"It was agreed by you while I was on a scaffold and unable to descend conveniently."

Messalla signalled to Herennius, who produced the estate note. The payment date was written as "when funds permit", a phrase that made Messalla want to banish adverbs and conditions from every agreement he owned.

"Why is the fourth man absent?" he asked.

"He is working for Octavius at the town fountain. Octavius pays on the day named."

The town fountain arrived in the conversation before its deputation could present it formally. Agathopus explained while they walked to the granary: the basin had cracked, a pipe needed replacing, and the local council hoped Messalla would contribute ten thousand sestertii. His grandfather's name was already carved on a nearby portico. A tasteful inscription could join it. Gnaeus Octavius, a magistrate with excellent teeth and a talent for treating requests as honours, would call after dinner.

Inside the granary, bins held barley and wheat in dusty abundance that looked greater than it was. Herennius ran a hand over the measure marks.

"Four hundred modii, perhaps a little less after settling," Agathopus said.

"How much is owed as payment in kind?" Messalla asked.

"Some. The tenants on the lower fields ask for a loan of sixty until harvest. Their winter store has finished early."

"Why?"

"A poor yield on the rented strip. Munatius sold too much in autumn to pay for his father's funeral."

"Did he?"

"He paid for a stone with lettering. And musicians."

Messalla looked at the grain. It would be easy to be severe about musicians at a funeral. His own father had been accompanied to the tomb by enough instruments to alarm the neighbouring dead.

Titus Munatius waited outside with his wife Helvia and a son of about twelve. They did not approach until Agathopus beckoned. The boy held a basket too large for the amount he expected to put in it, which gave the scene an optimism the adults lacked.

"We ask forty now," Munatius said. "Twenty more if the harvest is late. To be returned in kind with five extra for the use."

"Who set five?" Messalla asked.

"Agathopus."

The steward said, "It is customary."

Helvia added, "We have seed enough. It is food until the barley is ready. We will not eat the seed if the estate lends."

She spoke directly, without the wailing deference that made decisions easier by allowing them to be dismissed as performance. The boy kept his eyes on the basket.

Messalla asked about other families. Three could manage. Two needed smaller amounts. The widow on the upper strip

had lent beans to Munatius and expected repayment whether or not the estate intervened—a private economy of obligation running underneath his, probably with better records.

"Sell fifty modii now," Agathopus advised in a lower voice, "while the price is high. That and the cash reserve will cover the wall. The tenants can buy in town."

"With what?" Helvia asked, having heard him perfectly.

Messalla felt the familiar pressure of several correct actions demanding the same money. Pay the masons first; they had finished work. Lend grain; eating seed would create next year's default. Keep cash for the fifteenth; Severus's claim might become a public embarrassment. Contribute to the fountain; a town remembered a family that let its water fail while arguing over a warehouse.

He postponed all of them with a sentence.

"I will decide after the accounts tonight."

Dionysius gathered his plumb line. "My men decide in the morning."

"Is that a threat?"

"It is a calendar."

The mason returned to his stones. Helvia took the empty basket from her son before disappointment made him swing it into the granary door.

They inspected the cistern before dinner. Its channel had been laid by Messalla's grandfather along a line that looked admirable on the estate plan and less admirable where tree roots had entered the joints. Water escaped into a storeroom, darkening jars and softening a stack of baskets. Agathopus's granddaughter, a serious girl of about nine who had recovered from fever and now considered herself an authority on convalescence, showed them where the damp reached by placing one hand flat against the wall.

"Here when it rains," she said. "Here after. Fish would be happier."

"Would you like fish in the storeroom?" Herennius asked.

"I would like the jars dry. Fish can make their own arrangements."

Messalla ordered the channel cleared but no new pipe bought until Dionysius or another mason could judge the joints. It sounded decisive. It also postponed the expense, a harmony he noticed and tried not to admire.

On the lower terraces two rooted vines were indeed missing. The holes had been filled and smoothed by someone who understood that theft resembled agriculture if performed neatly. Agathopus blamed a neighbouring tenant. The neighbour blamed boys from Tibur. The boys of Tibur were not present to distribute blame further. Messalla told Agathopus to count every vine before accusing anyone who might owe them money for another reason.

"You think I exaggerate losses?" the steward asked.

"I think losses have a way of joining accounts where they will be warmly received."

At the upper strip they found the widow who had lent beans to Munatius. Her name was Rufa; her husband had died three years earlier and her married daughter worked the lease with her. She did not ask Messalla for grain. She asked whether, if the estate lent to Munatius, her own beans would be repaid before his new debt. Agathopus began to say the estate could not arrange private kindnesses. Messalla interrupted.

"How much did you lend?"

"Enough for eleven days, if people do not insist on celebrating."

Her daughter laughed. Rufa did not.

"Record it," Messalla told Herennius. "Munatius can acknowledge the order of repayment when he takes estate grain."

"We have not yet decided to lend," Agathopus said.

"Then record a hypothetical. You have experience."

Rufa offered them water from a ewer kept in the shade of a fig tree. Herennius drank. Messalla drank. The water tasted of clay and the afternoon. Such small courtesies continued regardless of whether the estate behaved well, which made them harder to accept than formal thanks.

On the walk back Agathopus said, "You encourage people to bring every debt to the house."

"They already bring them to the house. I am encouraging us to know in what order we have caused them."

Dinner that evening was taken on the terrace because Agathopus believed the view improved digestion and decisions. Octavius arrived with honeyed wine and a drawing of the proposed fountain. The design included a lion's head copied from somewhere respectable and space for an inscription in letters large enough for a man of Messalla's father's eyesight, although his father had been dead for years.

"The town remembers your family," Octavius said.

"The town remembers several families. It has a retentive thirst."

"Ten thousand would complete the basin and pipe. Five would begin."

"Five would begin a basin. Thirsty people are severe critics of beginnings."

Octavius laughed and waited for the refusal to become negotiation. Messalla looked at the drawing. His name had already been sketched lightly in the inscription space. It was faint, but someone had practised the letters.

"I will answer after the estate accounts are settled," he said.

"The council meets—"

"After the accounts."

When Octavius had gone, Herennius spread the books on the dinner table. The cash in hand, including what they had brought from Rome, was a little under twelve thousand. The masons were owed three thousand six hundred. New wall

work might cost another five. Grain sold now would bring a good price. Severus might demand something on the fifteenth—perhaps only a share of a first instalment, perhaps an attempt to make all owners answer because his proposal preferred solidarity. There were wages, a roof on the villa's east range, and the fountain waiting with his name pencilled on it.

Messalla made the decision that would allow every option to remain available in the morning. He kept the cash intact.

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In the morning, two of the three remaining masons had gone to the fountain.

Dionysius stood in the yard with his tools tied in a bundle. He was not angry in any way Messalla could use. Anger could be answered, purchased or waited out. This was the expression of a man who had revised an estimate.

"Octavius pays weekly and provides lime," he said. "I have a mother, two sons and a landlord. I cannot feed them on being considered after accounts."

"I can pay half now."

"You could have paid it yesterday."

"There were competing claims."

"There always are. Ours was the one already earned."

Messalla went into the house and had Herennius count out eighteen hundred. Dionysius accepted the money, signed for it, and divided it among the men who had left according to their shares. He remained beside the wall only long enough to show Agathopus which stones should not be moved until a competent team returned.

"When will that be?" Messalla asked.

"After the fountain, perhaps. If another job does not come. My second man has cousins in Rome."

He left with the tools on his shoulder. The goat watched him go, then butted the wooden prop under the bulging wall. The prop shifted half a finger's width. Agathopus shouted and seized the animal by its collar before either fact could become history.

Messalla ordered the tenant yard cleared and the prop doubled. He authorised forty modii to Munatius immediately, with the further twenty if the harvest was late, to be repaid in kind without the additional five Agathopus had proposed. Smaller loans were made to two other families, each entered separately. Helvia filled the large basket and another besides. The boy tried to lift both at once and was saved by his mother taking one handle without comment.

"You have given away the price advantage," Agathopus said.

"I have prevented us from selling hunger at a premium. Put it in the account in those words if it helps."

"It will not help."

"Then use numbers."

For the fountain he sent word to Octavius that he would not contribute this season. He offered instead the use of estate carts for hauling stone on two days when they were not needed, and instructed Agathopus to record the labour as paid estate work, not smuggle it into tenants' obligations. Octavius would likely present this as ancestral parsimony. The inscription space would be offered to someone else. Messalla found he could survive the absence of his name from wet stone.

By afternoon a local mason of less reputation had been found. Dionysius, encountered by Herennius near the gate with a message from the fountain site, agreed to return for one day to set the line and mark the dangerous stones, for a separate fee paid in advance. Messalla paid it. Pride would have been more expensive.

Dionysius arrived after the midday heat with chalk, line and a boy to carry them. He marked six stones for removal and two that could stay if the mortar behind them proved sound. The replacement mason, whose name was Eros and whose left thumb bore the history of his trade, listened without pretending the instruction was unnecessary.

"Can you finish before heavy rain?" Messalla asked him.

"I can make it safe. Finish is a larger animal."

"How much larger?"

Eros looked at Dionysius, who looked at the wall. Between them they produced an estimate neither would carve into the foundation: seven days, lime to be delivered, two labourers from the estate whose ordinary work would need covering. Messalla authorised the lime and one labourer. Agathopus objected that the vines required tying. Helvia, passing with an empty basket after returning the larger one to the granary, said Munatius could work two days on the wall after his own field in exchange for part of the grain loan being treated as wages.

Messalla disliked the conversion. It made hunger negotiate with masonry.

"No," he said. "The grain is a loan. Wall work will be paid if he chooses it. Do not let one debt eat the other."

Helvia nodded as if a distinction she valued had been preserved. Munatius, behind her, looked merely tired.

Dionysius also inspected the cistern channel. The roots could be cleared and one joint replaced; the storeroom wall would dry if ventilated, though the baskets were past saving. Agathopus's granddaughter followed with a lamp until sent away for bringing fire too close to a discussion of damp.

"You should do it before the jars are filled," Dionysius told Messalla.

"After the wall."

"That is what water likes to hear."

He took his advance and left for the fountain without shaking hands. Agathopus watched him down the track.

"He will come back when Octavius has no more work."

"Perhaps. People do. They do not necessarily bring the same opinion with them."

Herennius entered the day as three columns: wages paid in part, grain lent, materials authorised. The columns did not capture the fourth item, which was that two skilled men now associated the estate with waiting. Messalla made him add a note in ordinary language. Future readers of the account—sons, stewards, men in rooms smelling of roses—should not be able to mistake the delay for weather.

The rain strengthened after sunset. Agathopus stationed a farmhand near the tenants' yard with instructions to shout if the prop shifted, an arrangement that offered more noise than safety. Messalla went down himself once, in a cloak that immediately proved optimistic. The new prop held. Water ran from the terrace in a clean line where Eros had opened a channel. Munatius stood under the eaves with a lantern, keeping his own watch because his tools were beneath the wall and because being lent grain had not made him willing to leave the estate's dangers entirely to its employees.

"You should sleep," Messalla told him.

"So should the wall."

They listened to rain on leaves, earth, tiles and the goat's shelter. The goat complained at intervals, a small, wet commentary on management.

"If the harvest is poor," Munatius said, "we may not repay all in kind."

"Then repay what there is and we will discuss the rest before it becomes a secret."

"Agathopus dislikes discussion after sums."

"Agathopus will survive."

Back in the house Octavius's reply had arrived, sealed with more wax than the message required. He thanked Messalla

for the offer of carts, regretted that the family name could not be associated with the fountain at this time, and mentioned—without emphasis, which was its own emphasis—that Dionysius's team was performing admirably. Messalla read it beside the steward's fire.

"He will put his cousin's name above the lion," Agathopus said.

"Then his cousin may feed the lion."

"You care less than I expected."

"I care enough to have brought the letter in out of the rain."

He instructed Herennius to prepare for an early return. There were still vine counts, a cistern estimate, and the question of whether Agathopus's missing vines had walked to a neighbour or into the steward's imagination. Those could wait for a written report. The fifteenth could not, or at least Severus would claim it could not. Messalla was learning to distinguish urgency from a man standing near a calendar.

He ate in the steward's room that evening because rain had begun in the hills and the terrace view had become a study in grey. The bread was coarse, made from the same estate grain over which he had hesitated. Agathopus served lentils and a piece of cheese with more rind than a polite guest should have been offered. Messalla ate without remark.

"You could have sold the grain and kept Dionysius," Agathopus said.

"By paying the masons yesterday, yes."

"That is what I meant."

"Then say it."

The steward looked startled, then pleased in a cautious way. "You waited too long."

"I did."

It was not absolution either. The wall still bulged. The fountain would acquire another name. Dionysius might not return after setting the line. Severus remained in Rome with

his beautifully copied proposal. But the grain was in Munatius's house rather than converted into a price, and eighteen hundred sestertii had reached men who had earned more.

After dinner he wrote a brief note for Herennius to carry back to Rome: arrange the meeting with Antonia, Severus and Hilarus, and bring the estate entry showing where the previous distribution had gone. If the past was to be used against them, he preferred to carry his own copy.

Outside, rain tapped the roof tiles. Somewhere below, Helvia's boy was laughing as if a basket of grain had solved adventure. Messalla slept badly, listening for stone.

In the morning the prop still held. Eros had begun clearing behind the marked stones, and Munatius was repaying no one yet but had sent his son to Rufa with a written mark acknowledging that her beans came before the estate grain. Herennius recorded it between the wages and the lime. Agathopus objected that the estate archive was becoming a village memory. Messalla told him villages had survived worse filing systems.

Before leaving, he placed the remaining masons' balance—eighteen hundred still owed on the old section—into Agathopus's hands with instructions that it was not to be used for cistern pipes, stolen vines or any sudden opportunity involving the word "customary". When Dionysius or his men presented themselves, they were to be paid whether or not they agreed to resume the wall.

"Without your seal?" Agathopus asked.

"With Herennius's receipt entry and witnesses. My seal has done enough travelling."

The road back to Rome was wet in the hollows. At the first milestone Herennius asked whether he should send ahead to Severus about the proposed meeting.

"Yes," Messalla said. "And to Antonia. Separately. Let neither think the other has been allowed to draft my opinion."

He rode towards the city with less money than he had brought and more obligations accurately named. It did not feel like virtue. It felt like administration after a preventable embarrassment, which might have been virtue's working clothes.

CHAPTER SEVEN

What May Be Sold

Hermas kept his pens in a chipped cup and his conclusions behind a locked door.

Damaris noticed both while waiting in the outer room of Papirius's chambers. The cup said a man might be practical. The locked inner door said practicality did not extend to other people's documents. She approved of the door.

They had arrived early. Antonia wore a plain dress and no emeralds. Damaris wore the tunic she used for market accounts, clean, with her hair bound tightly enough to keep it from asking questions. Felix had remained at home with Meroe, under orders not to test the loose tooth against any items of furniture. Before leaving, he had asked whether lawyers ate breakfast. Damaris told him that even lawyers were mortal before noon.

A youth with ink on three fingers brought water. From behind the locked door came the sound of Papirius dictating in a voice so even that the words might have been laid in rows. Hermas, a narrow man with a bald head polished by lamps and a habit of touching each document at its corner before moving it, came out carrying a tablet.

"Antonia Cassia," he said. Then, to Damaris, "You are to speak first. That is what the message said."

"It is what I asked."

"Good. People send instructions and then become annoyed when followed. Come in."

The inner room had shelves of tied rolls, a table scarred by knife work, and a window giving onto a wall close enough to

make privacy plausible. Papirius himself was present only through a chair still warm from occupation and a half-finished letter weighted by a bronze frog. Hermas explained that he prepared statements and knew which questions the advocate would ask if the matter went further. He did not pretend to be Papirius, which raised him in Damaris's estimation.

"Age?" he asked.

"Thirty-two, as near as records allow. I was not consulted at my birth."

"Records?"

Antonia produced a copy of the purchase document from when Damaris had come to her. It gave a name, origin described in language Damaris despised, approximate age and the child as an addition that made her look at the table until the letters lost their individual ambition.

Hermas read it without comment. "The boy is ten."

"Yes."

"Born before the purchase?"

"Yes."

"Father?"

"No one whose name will open doors." The man had been a mule driver, kind in the limited way of people always about to leave, dead before Felix could say more than a handful of words. Damaris did not offer this. A locked door was for documents. She intended to keep some arrangements of her own.

Hermas wrote. "You want formal freedom for both."

"I want freedom that cannot be taken back when a mood changes. For both."

"Those are separate problems, which you are asking to keep at the same table."

"They live at the same table."

He nodded once. "For you, formal manumission is possible. Age, title, procedure. There will be tax and expenses. What obligations would follow to your patron can be discussed; they

are not invented by gratitude on the day. For the boy, because he is under thirty, a full and secure result requires an approved cause examined by the proper council. Informal arrangements can leave a person free in manner but incomplete in status, with property difficulties after death. A child cannot solve those by being well behaved."

"What causes are approved?" Antonia asked.

Hermas glanced at Damaris, permission and apology in one movement. "Family connections. A foster child raised in the household—an alumnus—may be argued. Long service alone is less certain. The facts must be sworn and supported. He has lived here since infancy. That helps. It does not turn a council into a market stall where the correct coin produces the desired object."

Damaris's hands were still in her lap. She examined their stillness as if it had been arranged by someone else.

"Could Antonia free me now and promise Felix later?"

"She could. A promise may be written. It may also meet death, debt, heirs, a change of mind, and all the other furniture of life."

"I would not change my mind," Antonia said.

Hermas lifted the purchase copy by one corner. "Madam, I prepare documents because minds are not archives."

Antonia's face tightened. Damaris felt an unworthy flicker of gratitude that someone else had said it.

"What would you do?" Damaris asked.

"I would prepare both cases together. Your son as alumnus of the household from infancy, with witnesses who can speak to his upbringing, your service, the household records, medical care, instruction. I would present your own formal manumission as ready but not execute it until the council's disposition towards the boy is known, if you insist on keeping them linked."

"I insist."

"Then we proceed on your refusal, not around it."

That sentence entered the room with the plainness of a chair being set down. Damaris looked at Hermas directly for the first time.

"What will it cost to prepare?"

"For statements, copies, witnesses' time, attendances: one thousand five hundred to begin. More if the council requires additional appearances. The tax will depend upon assessed value. Papirius will want his fee if he argues the cause."

"Assessed by whom?"

"People whose profession is to turn a life into a taxable event."

Antonia shifted. "I will pay the preparation."

Damaris said, "From what account?"

"Mine."

"And if I later refuse your patronal terms?"

"We have not discussed terms."

"Exactly."

Hermas put down his pen. He seemed to understand that there were conversations in which a clerk's silence could be part of the furniture. Antonia looked towards the bronze frog, perhaps because it had the decency not to offer an opinion.

"My peculium is six thousand four hundred and sixty," Damaris said. "Antonia has said she will add two thousand. If I am to buy preparation, buy it from that. Record hers separately."

"You know the peculium is not legally yours to direct as a free woman directs property."

"I know I keep its tally and everyone calls it mine until a creditor enters the room."

"That is an accurate summary with worse manners than the law's."

"Then let the law improve its manners after it explains itself."

Hermas almost smiled. He wrote the figures on a clean tablet and turned it so she could read them. His numbers

were upright, unadorned. Six four six zero. Two thousand. One thousand five hundred proposed.

"Do not decide the deposit today," he said. "Take the statement of the route. Think. If we proceed, I will need names of witnesses: someone who knew the boy as an infant, someone outside the immediate household if possible, anyone who instructed him, the physician who treated him. I will also need Antonia's title documents, your purchase record and an account of your duties that does not sound like an inscription."

"I keep the accounts," Damaris said.

"Then write them as accounts."

Papirius came in briefly between dictations, a heavy man with a quiet mouth and eyes that had retained their scepticism after professional use. Hermas summarised Damaris's position in four sentences, the last being her refusal to separate the cases.

"You understand," Papirius said to her, "that linking them may delay you."

"I understand that unlinking them may abandon him."

"That is a mother's logic. The council prefers documents."

"Then make the documents resemble the facts."

He looked at Hermas, not angrily. "She will be a difficult client."

"She is not technically—" Hermas began.

"Do not finish that in front of her if you value the furniture."

Papirius asked whether Felix had been educated for a trade, whether Antonia intended him for management, whether any person outside the house could swear he had been raised there rather than merely kept there. The distinction was unpleasant and useful. Kept could mean fed in a corner. Raised required names, illnesses treated, letters taught, punishments no worse than a free child might earn—though Papirius advised not volunteering a catalogue

of punishments unless one wished to discover the council's views on discipline.

"What happens if Antonia dies before this is done?" Damaris asked.

Antonia turned. "I am sitting here."

"That is why it is efficient to ask."

Papirius answered without decoration. A will could provide manumission, subject to its own rules, heir disputes and the state of the estate. It was not a substitute for acting in life if action was intended. Creditors also had a talent for reading wills. Damaris thought of Antonia in the kitchen doorway refusing to pay for a damaged fish. Death could arrive with the same lack of ceremony, between errands.

"And if she sells me?" she asked.

Antonia's hand struck the arm of her chair once, not loudly. "I will not."

"If she were forced?"

Papirius said, "Then an unexecuted preparation is only paper in a helpful room."

The silence that followed was the first completely honest furniture in the chambers.

"What obligations would I owe as a freedwoman?" Damaris asked.

"That depends on what is agreed and imposed. Respect. Services, if formally required. Do not sign a life dressed as gratitude. We can examine any terms before manumission."

Antonia said, "I am not asking her to remain forever."

"Then let us write the shape of not forever when the route is clearer. 'Not forever' has buried many afternoons."

Hermas made a list of witnesses in columns: household, outside, professional. Crispus. Meroe. The physician. Livia Tertulla, whose Subura shop books Damaris kept monthly. A fuller whose vat had contributed to Felix's biography. The list made a childhood look like a conspiracy to become visible.

Outside, the Forum noise reached them in pieces: a herald, horses, somebody arguing in the rhythm of a man who had prepared both sides. Antonia asked when a council might hear such a cause. Weeks. Perhaps longer. There were lists. There were men whose nephews required faster lists. Papirius would not bribe a place into existence, though he could remind officials of courtesies until they resembled one.

As they stood to leave, Hermas said, "One more matter. Do not let the boy be told he is about to be free."

Damaris stopped.

"Children spend promised things before adults have bought them," he said. "It makes refusal crueler."

"He already asks."

"Then answer what is true. You are seeking advice. Advice is a door seen from the street. It is not the room."

Antonia, who had used almost the same image in the small hours, looked at him with brief suspicion, as though doors had begun collaborating.

In the street the spring sun was hard and ordinary. A seller of violets had arranged his flowers in wet moss. Antonia bought a bunch without asking whom they were for and carried them until they began to wilt against her sleeve. Then she gave them to Damaris.

"For Meroe," she said.

"She will put them in water and scold the stems."

That was easier than discussing councils on a public road.

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The dealer came two days later, while Damaris was writing the account Hermas had requested.

She had begun three times. The first version listed duties: marketing, stores, guest arrangements, keys, supervision of laundry, letters for those who could not write, wages for hired musicians, household accounts under Crispus's direction. The

second added Felix: carried to Antonia Secunda's household as an infant, raised within it, taught letters by Crispus when work allowed, treated by a physician for fever at four and ear pain at ten. The third attempt stopped whenever a sentence began to sound grateful for the right to be enumerated.

The porter sent word that a man wished to speak to Antonia about a business opportunity. She was with a wine merchant in the garden room. Damaris, following custom, asked the visitor's name and business more particularly.

"Gaius Numisius," the porter said. "He deals in household staff. Trained staff."

The phrase travelled through the passage with its shoes off.

Damaris put down her pen. She could have sent him away. Antonia might have been angry at losing information or grateful at not being disturbed. Curiosity was not the emotion she would have chosen to admit. She sent Meroe to tell Antonia and received Numisius in the small court where tradesmen were kept from seeing more of the house than could be priced from there.

He was clean, smiling, with rings enough to make his hands look busy even at rest. He looked at Damaris's keys, her writing tablet, her face, in that order.

"You are the steward."

"I am."

"Literate?"

"I am writing an account of my duties."

"That answers the question and advertises the product. Is Antonia considering reducing expense? One hears of warehouse difficulties everywhere. A good manager, a singer, perhaps a boy with his future ahead of him—these are assets that lose value if a household waits for creditors to encourage it."

He said it pleasantly, as if offering to remove a stain.

"Who sent you?" Damaris asked.

"Opportunity."

"Opportunity has a great many clerks."

Antonia came through the doorway before he could answer. She had left the wine merchant with Crispus. Her face had the expression she wore when a guest asked for a woman by a characteristic instead of a name.

"Numisius," she said.

"You remember me."

"I remember your prices at Antonia Secunda's sale. They had a talent for rising when the family was in the room."

"Sentiment is a market force."

"What do you want?"

"To make an offer before others make cruder ones. For the singer Thaleia, if her voice is as reported. For your steward. Possibly the boy, separately or with his mother. Together can reduce trouble and therefore price."

The fountain in the court made its uneven sound. Felix, mercifully, was in the kitchen being prevented from educational eating.

"None of them is for sale," Antonia said.

Numisius nodded as if this were an opening posture. "For the steward alone, trained, literate, healthy, I could place eighteen thousand without embarrassing either of us. The boy at ten, if he has letters, perhaps four. Together—"

"You may stop adding."

"It is useful to know."

"For you."

"For anyone assessing a household. Severus has been asking what security exists beyond warehouses."

Antonia's stillness changed quality.

"Did Severus send you?"

"Severus sends very few people. He creates weather and lets them walk in it."

"Leave."

He bowed to her, then, with professional completeness, to Damaris. "If circumstances alter, my office is by the cattle market. A discreet sale is kinder than a public one."

After the gate closed Antonia said, "He will not be admitted again."

Damaris looked at the tablet in her hand. The latest sentence said Felix had been taught letters when work allowed. Eighteen thousand. Four thousand. Together could reduce trouble and therefore price.

"He did not need admission to price us," she said.

"He wanted me frightened."

"Are you?"

Antonia took the tablet, read the unfinished account, and handed it back.

"I am angry."

"That is not the answer either."

The wine merchant laughed at something Crispus said in the garden room. The sound was indecently normal.

Antonia said, "Would you rather I had let him finish?"

"No. I would rather the law did not make your refusal the only wall between my son and his arithmetic."

She went back to the account room. Her hand shook on the first letter, so she wrote the market list instead: oil, salt, plums if firm, lamp wicks. By the time she reached wicks the line was steady.

Later Felix brought her a piece of pastry shaped like a fish. The cook had made it from trimmings. One eye was a currant.

"Is it for me?" she asked.

"You look like you have been doing sums that bite."

She ate the tail. "Then it is medicine."

He watched until she smiled, not because a child of ten could repair the afternoon but because he needed evidence that her face still performed its ordinary functions. She gave him the evidence and sent him to Meroe before the cook could call pastry another lesson.

Thaleia came to the account room after practice, her instrument still in her hand. She had heard from the porter that a dealer had asked whether her voice was as reported.

"Did he offer a price for me?"

"No. Antonia stopped him at us."

"I don't know whether to be insulted." Thaleia sat on the low stool where petitioners waited for letters. "What did he say for you?"

"Eighteen."

"Thousand?"

"Dealers rarely offer eighteen pears."

Thaleia plucked a string so softly it might have been a thought. She had been bought at fifteen for a voice that made a previous owner's guests stop chewing. Now at twenty-three she could read music, manage a drunken patron's request into harmlessness, and tell by the first course whether an evening wanted Greek songs or Roman sentiment.

"If Antonia sold me," she said, "would a theatre be worse?"

"Different men. Larger rooms."

"That is not an answer."

"No. It is geography."

They looked at one another. Damaris had little patience for conversations that circled danger while pretending to be philosophy, but Thaleia's question had a practical edge. A singer's value depended on health, fashion, the condition of a throat. A steward's depended on being trusted with keys. Felix's depended on a future no one should have been allowed to discount by four thousand.

"She said none of us is for sale," Damaris told her.

"Today."

"Yes. Today is the day we have with her saying it."

Crispus came in with the wine merchant's receipt and stood listening uninvited, a privilege age and shared servitude had made complicated. "Numisius knew Thaleia's name," he said. "And that Felix has letters. Someone talks."

"Everyone talks," Thaleia said. "It is how houses breathe. Sometimes it is also how they rot."

"Porter?"

"Perhaps. Or a guest. Or Severus asking questions until answers begin walking around by themselves."

Antonia was informed and gave instructions: Numisius and any dealer were to be refused at the gate; inquiries about staff were to receive no names; the porter was not to be beaten on suspicion because fear would make him invent a more entertaining confession. Damaris approved of the last instruction, though she knew approval was not required.

That night Felix asked, while she was checking the loose tooth with one clean finger, "Can people buy keys?"

"Keys can be made."

"I mean the person carrying them."

Her hand stopped. "Who told you that?"

"No one. A man at the gate said together reduces trouble. Cook said he was a weasel in rings."

Damaris removed her finger and wiped it. "A man asked whether Antonia wanted to sell people. She said no."

"Could she?"

The legal answer was yes. The maternal answer was a wall built out of the material available.

"She has said she will not. We are also asking the lawyer's clerk how freedom can be made in a way that cannot simply be changed. That is all anyone knows."

Felix worked the tooth with his tongue. "If we were sold together, would the road know?"

She took the grey pebble from her pouch and put it on the blanket between them. "The road and I have an arrangement."

He picked it up, satisfied for the moment by evidence small enough to hold. Damaris stayed until the pebble slipped from his fingers in sleep. Then she returned it to her pouch, because promises between mother and child required the

same custody as other valuables: constant, imperfect, and preferably not left out for dealers.

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"We will deposit the first fifteen hundred with Hermas," Damaris said the next morning.

Antonia was at breakfast, if olives and bread eaten while reading a builder's estimate could be promoted to breakfast. Crispus stood by the table with the warehouse papers. Hilarus had now supplied a carter's name in a second copy: Philoxenus, or possibly Philogenes, depending on whether a loop in the writing was ambition or accident. A meeting with Severus was being urged before the payment date became another weapon. Antonia's domestic empire was once again full of men’s handwriting.

"For preparation," Damaris added.

Crispus looked at Antonia.

"Do not look at her," Damaris said. "I am asking for an entry."

"You are asking for money to leave the house," Crispus replied. "I am permitted to look at several people."

"From my peculium."

"Which—"

"I know. Say it once for the record."

Crispus folded his arms. "Which legally can be taken back, pursued by your owner's creditors, or spent by your owner while everyone continues to call it yours out of affection and convenience."

"Thank you."

"It is an ugly paragraph. I keep it ready."

Antonia put the estimate down. "If Hermas holds it as payment for work instructed, it is at least spent on the case."

"Some of it."

"I want the rest inventoried," Damaris said. "My six thousand four hundred and sixty, less fifteen hundred if deposited. Your two thousand written separately as promised towards costs, not added to make my savings look larger. A copy with Hermas. A copy with Crispus. A copy with me if paper is not too revolutionary."

"It does not make the money proof against a creditor," Antonia said.

"I know. I am not asking for proof. I am asking that if it vanishes, it vanish from a page with witnesses."

Crispus fetched the peculium tally. It was kept in a wooden box with other household small accounts, which Damaris had always known and never quite looked at from this angle. The coins themselves were not all in the box. Some of the sum was represented by entries: a New Year gift retained, fees for letters, a small amount owed by a freedwoman in the Subura who paid Damaris to keep her late husband's shop books one afternoon a month. That woman, Livia Tertulla, could perhaps witness that Damaris handled accounts outside Antonia's house. Hermas had wanted somebody outside the immediate household. The world offered connections if she looked at it as a case rather than a corridor.

They counted what coin there was: three thousand eight hundred in mixed silver. The rest existed as obligations and Antonia's bookkeeping. Fifteen hundred could be sent in actual coin. Crispus recorded the denominations because he was constitutionally unable to let money travel anonymously.

Antonia added her two thousand to a separate line, not to the box. "Towards council and tax costs," she dictated. "Not a loan."

"And if the petition fails?" Damaris asked.

"Then I will have spent money learning a door is shut."

"And my fifteen hundred?"

"Spent on preparation."

Damaris considered. It was possible to spend the price of a future proving the future unavailable. It was also possible to keep the money untouched for a trader's convenience.

"Send it," she said.

Crispus wrote a receipt instruction for Hermas to sign: fifteen hundred received from Antonia Cassia on Damaris's direction for preparation of linked manumission statements for Damaris and her son Felix, accounting to be rendered. Antonia read it and changed "her son Felix" from a place after a comma, where grammar might have lost him, to a position nearer the front. It was a small edit. Damaris noticed.

Meroe and Thaleia were called to witness the household inventory copy. Their evidence as enslaved women had limits Hermas would explain; their memory had fewer. Thaleia signed her name in practised letters. Meroe made a mark and then, dissatisfied, asked Crispus to write beside it that she had known Felix since he fitted in a laundry basket.

"That is not relevant to money," Crispus said.

"It is relevant to the boy," Meroe replied.

He wrote it in a margin, where relevance often went to be useful later.

A messenger took the coin and instruction that afternoon. Damaris went with him as far as the gate but not into the street. The bag looked unremarkable. So had most of the important containers in her life: baskets, boxes, a child's fist around a pebble.

Hermas's signed acknowledgement would come back before evening. It would render the sum, the purpose and the link between the cases in clerkly Latin Damaris could read twice. At the bottom he would add that no hearing date was promised and no outcome represented. She would respect the sentence as one respects a cold floor: it told the truth about where she stood.

That afternoon she went to Livia Tertulla's shop in the Subura for the monthly books. Permission was given in the

usual way—Antonia told her to return before the dinner fish required a decision—and yet every street between the houses reminded Damaris that leaving by permission was not the same as leaving.

Livia sold secondhand clothing of respectable quality to people experiencing temporary reductions in fortune. She was a freedwoman of sixty with a memory for stains and a marriage that had survived because she and her husband maintained separate strongboxes and adjoining sarcasm. Her shop books were accurate until sentiment entered; then nieces acquired coats at prices resembling weather.

Damaris corrected three entries before asking whether Livia would witness that she had handled the books for four years and had sometimes brought Felix, who had once hidden among cloaks and been discovered by sneezing.

"For a court?" Livia asked.

"For a council, perhaps. To show Felix was raised in Antonia's house and that I can do accounts outside it."

"Will they ask why you were allowed out?"

"They may ask anything."

"Then tell them Antonia is not a fool. She lends competence where it earns gratitude."

Damaris wrote Livia's name in her list. "Would you swear it?"

"I have sworn worse things for cheaper coats. Yes." Livia pushed a cup of sour wine towards her. "If you are freed, will you still do my books?"

"If you pay me."

"I pay now."

"You pay Antonia a consideration and me in excellent advice."

"Advice has kept you alive."

"So has soup. I do not plan to retire on it."

Livia laughed, then took a coat from the rail and held it against Damaris. It was dark blue, repaired invisibly at one

elbow. "For the council day. You should not arrive dressed as a household implement."

"I am not buying a coat for a door that may not open."

"Try it. Doors can smell despair."

Damaris did not buy it. She allowed Livia to write her name on a tag inside the collar and put it aside for a month, a compromise between hope and accounting. On the walk home the tag seemed more dangerous than the deposit receipt.

Antonia, when told, said, "A coat?"

"I did not buy it."

"You reserved a future in dark blue."

"I reserved a coat. Do not improve it."

Her expression softened. "If the petition proceeds, what work would you want afterwards?"

It was the first time Antonia had asked the question without immediately supplying a household answer.

"Paid work. Perhaps here for a time, at agreed hours. Perhaps Livia's books and others. A room that is not beside the storeroom. Felix at a school where letters are not fitted around musicians."

"You would leave?"

"I do not know. Leaving is a door too."

Antonia looked at the unfinished account. "Papirius warned about terms. I will not require daily service forever to prove gratitude."

"Put things like that aside until Hermas says what can be written."

"Yes."

It was a small obedience, and she performed it as if it had edges.

That evening she completed the account for Hermas. She wrote that Felix could read short passages and write his name, that Crispus corrected his letters when accounts were quiet, that the physician had attended him, that Meroe had known him since the laundry basket. She wrote that he had

never lived outside Antonia's household except for errands and one disastrous visit to a fuller where he fell into a vat of clean water and was considered improved. She did not write that he called stopped ships sleeping. Councils were unlikely to be moved by maritime misunderstanding.

Antonia came to the doorway with Messalla's reply, which had arrived while Damaris was deciding whether the fuller belonged in a legal narrative. She held it without opening it in Damaris's presence.

"Good news?" Damaris asked.

"It is correspondence. News would require it to be opened."

"Then open it somewhere else. I am making myself sound orderly."

Antonia almost left. At the threshold she said, "Numisius will spread the prices."

"Yes."

"That may be why he came."

"Prices are a kind of gossip with better posture."

Antonia nodded and went away to read whatever Messalla had chosen to put in a letter. Damaris sanded the page, checked that Felix's name remained near the front, and set her copy beneath the household tablets. The keys at her waist knocked together when she stood. They sounded, for an instant, like coins being counted in another room.

She went to find Felix before bed. He was helping Meroe wind thread, a task designed by adults who valued stillness over accuracy. The thread had formed a shape no garment would willingly claim.

"Did the clerk say yes?" he asked.

"He said there is a way to ask properly."

"That sounds like no with stairs."

"It is work with stairs."

He considered the phrase, then returned to the thread. Meroe said nothing, but her needle moved more slowly.

Damaris sat and untangled what could be untangled without cutting. Some knots yielded when she found the loose end. One did not. She put it aside for morning, when there would be better light and perhaps less temptation to solve things by force.

Before sleeping she checked the inventory copy once more. Four thousand nine hundred and sixty of the peculium remained after the deposit, if every entry could be made to stand where it claimed to stand. Antonia's separate two thousand waited in figures, not yet coin in her hand. The numbers were neither safety nor freedom. They were a record that she had begun to spend towards both, knowing the room might still refuse her at the door.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Guest List

On her first morning behind Claudia's counter, Nysa sold the wrong oil to the right woman.

The customer had asked for rose. Nysa, reaching without looking because she wished to appear born among jars, gave her one scented with iris and costlier by three denarii. The woman opened it in the doorway, sniffed, and announced that this was what she had meant all along. Claudia said nothing until the door closed.

"You are saved by vanity," she told Nysa. "Do not inventory it as skill."

By noon Nysa had learnt the arrangement of the shelves, mispronounced the name of an Egyptian unguent in a way Claudia promised to remember at her funeral, and sold two combs by advising a bride's mother that a daughter's hair should not be made to carry the whole alliance. Her feet hurt. The stool behind the counter was reserved for Claudia's bad knee and, apparently, moral instruction.

"You could sit between customers," Claudia said.

"When there are none, I might become one of the jars."

"You have the posture."

Nysa liked the shop's noises: the scrape of the spatula, glass against wood, women negotiating in the tone of people who considered themselves uniquely immune to flattery while presenting themselves for its administration. Men came too, buying for mothers, wives, mistresses and unnamed recipients whose existence grew less plausible as the jars

grew smaller. Nysa learned to ask, "For hair, skin, or apology?" It saved time.

The bride's mother arrived with artillery in the form of an aunt. Between them they possessed four opinions about hair, three about the groom's prospects, and a determination to purchase nothing that could be interpreted as desperation. The bride herself, a girl of nineteen with a bruise on one wrist from moving furniture, stood behind them touching the ends of her hair.

"We do not want her looking painted," the mother said.

"Or pleased with herself," the aunt added. "Confidence at a wedding can be mistaken for prior experience of weddings."

Nysa asked the bride what she wanted. The question caused a silence in which female generations could be heard rearranging themselves.

"To smell like myself on a better day," the girl said.

Nysa chose a light oil, showed her how little to use, and advised against a false fringe that Claudia could have sold twice over. The mother bought the oil, then the fringe anyway for herself. The aunt bought a comb after declaring combs a vanity of the young. Everyone left believing compromise had been achieved on her own terms.

"You lost a sale," Claudia said.

"I gained a woman who may return after the wedding, when the alliance has actual requirements."

"Now you sound like me. I shall have to increase your price to myself."

A boy came to collect a jar for the bath attendant and tried to pay with a token from another shop. Claudia sent him back with the token and a message about civilised currency. Nysa swept spilt powder from the threshold before a customer could track it into the street in white footprints. She was learning that business dignity was composed mainly of noticing small messes before they became public.

Crispus's opposite number arrived after the midday lull. His name was Aulus Terentius, and he did accounts for two bakers and a Spanish oil dealer, which in Nysa's judgement made him qualified to detect both crumbs and adulteration. He was a freedman with a squint acquired over many columns. He read Claudia's accounts standing, then sat, which Claudia interpreted as a bad omen.

"Your rent is fair for the position," he said. "Your stock turns well until winter. You allow too much credit to women with good jewellery and bad memories. The Spanish dealer owes you one thousand eight hundred, not the two thousand four hundred you have written here."

Claudia put a hand to her chest. "He told me—"

"He told you a number while handing you a sample. This is an old commercial sacrament."

Nysa had brought her own figures. Nine thousand two hundred saved. Beyond that, three hundred was owed by the man in Antium and might as well have been painted on a cloud. A gold bracelet, a pair of earrings she disliked, and a length of undyed silk could be sold if necessary. Terentius advised her to value them at what a dealer would pay on a bad day, not what a lover had claimed they cost.

"Men inflate gifts for the same reason they inflate fish," he said.

"To prove they were at sea?" Nysa asked.

"To prove the sea noticed."

The one-third share at sixteen thousand included stock that Terentius valued nearer thirteen if the Spanish debt failed and the brother-in-law's claim to the counter had to be bought off. Claudia objected, then began bargaining against her own document with an energy Nysa admired. By the time the shop boy brought water, a possible price had become fourteen thousand five hundred if Nysa also worked three days a week until the lease renewal. The landlord still required a property

guarantor and payment of the renewed portion before the Kalends of June.

"Could Claudia guarantee me to her own landlord?" Nysa asked.

"She could. He would then ask who guarantees Claudia."

"I own the stock," Claudia said.

"You own some of the stock on alternate pages."

Terentius ticked items with a fingernail. He advised a written agreement distinguishing purchase money, wages for shop work, Claudia's brother-in-law's claim, and who could dismiss a shop assistant. "Affection is excellent for perfume," he said. "In partnerships it evaporates."

He charged forty sestertii for the morning's opinion. Nysa paid him from her purse rather than the saved box, but money had a way of recognising its relatives.

Claudia's brother-in-law arrived before Terentius had gathered his tablets. His name was Gaius, a fact Rome had distributed too widely for individual blame. He carried a carpenter's receipt softened at the folds and the manner of a man who had rehearsed indignation in a mirror that charged by the hour.

"Nine hundred," Claudia said before he opened his mouth. "I remember. Publius the carpenter remembered until he died and left the memory in your custody."

"With interest, loss of use and the insult of delay, two thousand five hundred."

Terentius held out his hand for the receipt. Gaius looked at it as if hands were a recent fraud.

"Who is he?"

"An accountant," Nysa said.

"Then he need not touch the original."

"I can read at a distance when the ink is honest."

The receipt was for timber, nails and two days' labour. It did not mention a partnership in the shop, ownership of a counter, or pickled fish storage, although Gaius supplied

these as commentary. Eleven years ago he had paid Publius because Claudia's husband lay ill and a customer had broken the old counter by leaning on it in a moment of nuptial despair. Since then he had eaten at Claudia's table, stored fish jars in her back room for one winter, borrowed small sums returned in small apologies, and now saw the counter as the foundation of the enterprise.

"It holds the money box," he said. "Without it, there is no shop."

"Without customers there is a counter in a room," Claudia said. "Would you like to buy that?"

Nysa sold a pot of hair salve to a woman who appeared to enjoy the argument as a sample of local culture. Gaius lowered his voice when he realised commerce did not stop for his claim.

Terentius advised: nine hundred repaid if Claudia wished the matter closed, plus perhaps two hundred for delay, against a written release. Two thousand five hundred would require either a court, a richer memory, or a carpenter resurrected for examination.

"You see what happens when women bring in accounts?" Gaius said.

"Yes," Nysa replied. "Numbers lose their homes."

He took his receipt away under his cloak, promising to consult a cousin who remembered everything, including events the participants had been too inconsiderate to arrange. Claudia waited until the door closed.

"He will accept eleven hundred and tell the street it was three thousand."

"Then write eleven and let the street keep the other numbers warm," Terentius said.

The possible price to Nysa moved again. She was learning that fourteen thousand five hundred was less a figure than a chair in a room full of relatives, each arriving with a cushion and a claim.

In the afternoon the Antium debtor's servant arrived with one hundred of the three hundred owed and a message that his master retained the warmest memories. Nysa gave a receipt for one hundred and wrote beneath it, in her clearest hand, that memories were not accepted in settlement of the remainder. The servant read it, laughed despite professional training, and promised to deliver the document unaltered.

Her savings became nine thousand three hundred in theory. In practice, she spent two denarii on roasted beans because the baths were nearby and the seller remembered her. Independence had appetites.

Claudia let her close the shop. The shutter stuck halfway and required a shoulder. Nysa used hers and felt a small, ridiculous pride that had nothing to do with beauty.

"Tomorrow," Claudia said, "we will see whether you can sell to a woman who has brought her mother as artillery."

"Is that an engagement or a threat?"

"At my age, all invitations are both."

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The merchant from Narbo was named Lucius Domitius Corvus. He had buried his wife in winter and had been telling people since spring that he did not intend to make grief a profession, while accepting every invitation at which the profession might be discussed.

Antonia seated Nysa between Domitius and Sabina, as agreed. Sabina wore blue and an expression of profoundly available sympathy. After twenty minutes she had learnt the names of Domitius's late wife, her childhood dog, and a vineyard wall whose collapse had almost reconciled them after an argument in their third year of marriage.

"You see?" Antonia murmured when she passed behind Nysa's couch. "Sabina is providing depth."

"She is providing a harbour. I am the dangerous coast."

Domitius was not unattractive. He was about fifty, weather-browned, with silver at his temples and good hands. He ate sparingly, drank less than his partners, and asked Nysa about Narbonese wine without requiring her to pretend that cargo lists were poetry.

"Antonia says you are considering a shop," he said during the fish.

"Antonia says many things in a tone that makes them sound arranged."

"She said you would refuse help from her."

"Then she has been accurate and indiscreet in the same sentence."

He smiled. "I own property in Rome. Warehouses near the river, a house let to a grain factor. I could stand guarantor for a lease."

The table was full of small sounds: a spoon against a shell dish, Thaleia beginning a song at the far end, Sabina asking a partner whether ships became lonely. Nysa felt none of the dizziness that was supposed to accompany fortune. Her attention narrowed to Domitius's thumb resting against his cup.

"What would you want?" she asked.

"At first? Your company when I am in Rome. Perhaps exclusivity. I am too old to enjoy being one appetite among twelve at a table."

"And when you are not in Rome?"

"You would have the shop."

"And be exclusive to a timetable."

"I would not ask you to close the shop when a man enters to buy oil."

"How generous of commerce."

He did not take offence. That was part of his equipment. "I could also lend the difference. Six thousand. Seven, if the stock requires it. At a fair rate."

"Fair to whom, after exclusivity is placed in the other scale?"

"You make affection sound like an accounting fraud."

"I make it sound like a term. Terms prefer daylight."

Antonia had moved to speak to a partner from Narbo about customs charges. She was fulfilling her part of the agreement with unusual purity: paying Nysa in advance, arranging the carriage, and not rescuing her from a conversation she was capable of ending.

Domitius said, "My wife used to tell me I negotiated when I should court."

"What did you answer?"

"That in our family negotiation had better manners."

Nysa laughed, then remembered the scar and narrowed it too late. He noticed.

"Does it hurt?"

"Only when I find things funny before considering the man who caused it."

"Varro?"

She set down her cup. "You know."

"I heard there was an incident. Antonia expelled him. His friends call it a misunderstanding over manners."

"Do they?"

"Some call you difficult."

"That has followed me since before his hand did."

Domitius refilled her cup himself, which made Sabina glance over with interest. He did not touch Nysa's wrist, her hair, or the air beside her shoulder where men placed preliminary claims.

"I dislike being told whom to invite," he said. "It is one of the few vices wealth should purchase."

"Then why ask me to accept the condition?"

"Because I want what I want. Honesty is not the same as selflessness."

She respected him more for saying it. Respect was not desire, and desire, if it arrived, would need to apply separately.

"I will not take a guarantor whose price is my calendar," she said. "If you wish to lend as other men lend, with documents and interest and no rights over my evenings, my accountant can read it."

"I might."

"You might also discover that documents cool you."

"They frequently do. That is why they survive romance."

The song ended. Applause travelled the room like small change being counted. One of the Narbonese partners, a man whose rings suggested his fingers had independent commercial standing, asked Nysa to sing something from the Greek islands.

"I am not engaged as a musician tonight," she said.

"Surely one song—"

Thaleia lifted her instrument a fraction. She had heard this negotiation in every room in Rome: a request was made to sound too small to price and too rude to refuse.

Antonia, from two couches away, said, "Thaleia is our singer. Nysa is a guest."

The partner recovered by praising Thaleia with the enthusiasm of a man paying a toll on a bridge he had hoped to swim under. Domitius watched Nysa rather than the rescue.

"You dislike singing?" he asked when the music resumed.

"I like it when I have agreed to it. So does Thaleia, who is paid even when men decide her voice arrived by weather."

Thaleia's next phrase gained a small ornament. It might have been gratitude. It might have been a warning that musicians kept accounts in melody.

Later, Sabina became involved in an earnest discussion with the ringed partner about whether a ship could be said to miss its home port. Domitius told Nysa about his sister, who ran his Roman household when he travelled and corrected his

letters with a violence usually reserved for public inscriptions.

"She says I should either remarry or stop expecting other people's dinners to provide domestic rhythm."

"She may be right."

"She often is. It has made her difficult to surprise with agreement."

"Would she like me?"

"She would interrogate you about oils, decide you were either a fortune hunter or a genius, and serve the better wine if genius won."

"And if fortune hunter?"

"The wine remains good. She believes poor wine gives enemies a legitimate grievance."

For the first time that evening, Nysa wanted to meet someone from his account more than she wanted to inspect his possible loan. That was not an argument for accepting his terms. It was an argument for accepting his sister's invitation if it was paid as work and not staged as inspection by family council.

Domitius asked whether she would visit his sister's house for music the following week, as a paid guest, no private arrangement. Nysa said her fee and carriage terms would be the same. He agreed without first telling her how refreshing her directness was, which improved him further.

At the end of the evening he paid Thaleia generously and tipped the door porter. In the hall he said, "I will think about being merely a lender. It is a humbling costume."

"Try it before deciding it doesn't fit."

Her carriage was waiting. Antonia came out with the agreed fee already in her hand, although it had been paid in advance—this handful was for the additional hour the Narbonese partners had kept the table by discovering an argument about barrels. She counted it openly.

"You could have the shop tomorrow," Antonia said, low.

"I could have a shop with a man in it tomorrow."

"He is not Varro."

"No. He is better spoken. That is not the same as free of charge."

Antonia closed Nysa's fingers around the coins. "Then I will keep my money and my advice in separate rooms."

"Your house is improving."

The carriage took her through streets where late drinkers were negotiating with gravity. At her lodging, the landlady had left a lamp and a note asking whether she intended to renew the room for summer. Independence had mail.

In the morning Sabina arrived with two plum cakes and the expression of a woman bringing supplies to a siege.

"Antonia did not send me," she said.

"That is exactly what a woman sent by Antonia would say while carrying cakes."

"Then Antonia has trained me beautifully." She put the cakes on Nysa's table and looked around the single room: bed, chest, a shelf of jars, a dress airing by the window. "It is smaller than I imagined."

"What did you imagine? A courtyard?"

"I imagined independence would have better furniture."

"It has a door that locks. The furniture is intimidated."

Sabina ate half a cake before delivering her actual errand. At the baths she had heard a woman say Nysa had demanded money from Varro to keep silent about Antonia's house. Another said Varro had only pushed her because she had laughed at his receding hair.

"Did I laugh at his hair?" Nysa asked.

"No. You said his wig builder was resting, but that was about you."

"I see my wit has been reassigned."

"Should I correct people?"

"Only if you are there and it costs you nothing more than the sentence. Do not become my herald. Heralds get shot by both armies and then have to make their own tea."

Sabina considered this while eating the other half of her cake. "Domitius liked you."

"Domitius liked the possibility of terms."

"His wife died in winter. I felt sorry for him."

"You feel sorry professionally. It is your finest instrument."

"Is that cruel?"

"It is accurate. Play it for men who pay."

Nysa gave her the second cake to take back to Thaleia, then wrote down the names of people who had repeated the story, not to confront them but to know which rooms were weather and which were climate. The list fitted on one tablet. She wished it had been either much shorter or long enough to dismiss as Rome itself.

• • •

The cancellations arrived separately, each dressed as its own reasonable event.

First, an advocate's steward returned the little ivory token she used to confirm an engagement. The dinner would be family only. Then Statilia, who arranged musicians and female guests for men too respectable to know where either could be found, cancelled two evenings in one message. A widow who had hired Nysa to read Greek letters and provide conversation at a birthday luncheon wrote that her daughter had taken a sudden interest in reading them herself.

Nysa went to Statilia's rooms above a dyer's shop. The stairs smelt of urine and mordant. Statilia, sixty and painted with a confidence that had outlived several complexions, received her among lists of names.

"Is it Varro?" Nysa asked.

"It is never one man. That would make him important."

"That is precisely what he is trying to purchase."

Statilia tapped a stylus against the lists. "He says you accepted particular terms and then made a scene to increase your price. He says Antonia owes him money. He says a host who invites trouble should not blame the weather when it rains."

"None of that is true."

"Truth is only one of my columns." She turned the tablet. Names had been marked with dots whose meanings she did not explain. "Two hosts asked whether you might cause a scene. One wife asked whether you were Antonia's creature. A man who wants you asked whether discretion could be arranged at his farm, which means he believes scandal is a sauce."

Nysa read the names she recognised. The loss was not universal. It did not need to be. Three engagements in ten days, perhaps two thousand four hundred in fees and gifts, removed from a future she had been treating as income.

"What would repair it?" she asked.

"Time. A visible protector. A dinner at which you are charming and nobody bleeds from the mouth."

"Domitius has invited me to his sister's."

"Then go. Smile at his sister until your scar files a complaint."

"And Varro?"

Statilia shrugged. "Men like him believe access is a public road. They become patriots when a gate is closed."

Nysa paid Statilia the small commission still owed from an earlier evening. It seemed important to leave with accounts clean, even if reputation was smudged.

She called next on the widow who had withdrawn the birthday luncheon. It was not a confrontation; Nysa brought a small jar from Claudia's as a sample and was received in a room where Greek letters lay in a basket beside knitting. The widow, Caesia, was seventy and perfectly capable of reading

Greek. Her interest in Nysa had never been literacy. She liked a younger woman who could discuss Alexandria without confusing it with perfume and who did not treat old age as a room already emptied.

"My daughter heard your name coupled with a blow," Caesia said. "She fears the grandchildren will ask questions."

"They are four and six. They ask whether fish have grandmothers."

"Precisely. Once inquiry begins, who knows where it will stop?"

They drank watered wine. Caesia would not restore the luncheon, but she bought the jar and promised to send her niece to Claudia's shop. It was a coin placed gently over a crack.

The advocate's steward was less decorative. He returned the token in a doorway while a dog tried to escape between his ankles.

"Family only," he repeated.

"Your master has no family under forty except a nephew who recites."

"Then it will be an intimate catastrophe."

She could have argued. It would have employed the afternoon and fed the story. Instead she asked whether the steward's wife still bought the green salve for her hands and told him Claudia had a new batch. He looked startled, then bought a pot the following day and sent a boy so Nysa would not have to be recognised. Retaliation had many clerks too.

At the jeweller's, the earrings were weighed by a man whose apprentices had been trained not to look at sellers' faces while prices were being calculated. He offered four hundred and eighty. Nysa asked six hundred. They settled at five hundred and forty because she could name the workmanship and he enjoyed being resisted by someone who did not pretend the gold had a biography.

She did not tell him a provincial tax official had given them to her after explaining, at length, that cultured women preferred restraint. She had worn them twice. Let restraint finance rent.

At Claudia's shop she worked the afternoon with an energy that broke one small jar and sold six others. Claudia charged her for the jar at cost and then paid her day's shop wage without deducting consolation. They were becoming businesswomen together in the least sentimental way available.

That evening her landlady increased the summer rent because a cousin from Capua was willing to take the room and had praised the stairs. Nysa sold the earrings she disliked to a dealer who gave her less than a lover's claim and more than Terentius's bad-day estimate. She put part of the money aside for rent and part towards the shop. The division made both amounts look insulted.

Her saved box, if all entries were believed, now held nine thousand seven hundred and some small change. But the shop price might be fourteen thousand five hundred, the landlord wanted his portion before June, Claudia's brother-in-law had written claiming repayment for the counter, and the Spanish dealer still owed money whose size depended on who was telling the story.

Domitius's sister's evening went well. The sister was a widow with a sharper tongue than her brother and a musician nephew who played as if the lyre owed him money. Nysa sang one song, talked to an elderly aunt about hair dye, and was paid in full. A guest who had heard Varro's version watched her all evening for signs of meteorological disturbance. She disappointed him by eating neatly.

On the way home Domitius walked her to the carriage.

"I have thought about being merely a lender," he said.

"And?"

"I find I am not interested in financing a woman merely because she has an excellent plan."

"Then we understand the interest you intended to charge."

He bowed, neither angry nor redeemed. "If you change your mind—"

"I will know where your ships are."

At the shop next morning, Claudia was arguing with her brother-in-law through a written message because face-to-face architecture gave him courage. He wanted two thousand five hundred for the counter, although he had paid a carpenter nine hundred eleven years earlier and had since used the shop as a place to store two unsuccessful ventures in pickled fish. Terentius advised offering nine hundred plus interest if he produced a receipt. He produced instead a cousin who remembered everything.

Nysa measured oil for a customer whose husband objected to perfume, welcomed spring and expected his wife to embody it. The woman bought the larger jar this time.

"You could accept Antonia as guarantor," Claudia said after she left.

"I could also accept Domitius, Varro's version of events, and a life arranged by Statilia's dots."

"One of those may be less bad."

"Yes. That is how bad bargains dress for dinner."

Claudia wiped the counter where oil had escaped. "If the landlord gives us until the Kalends, we have days, not seasons. I can reduce my price only so far before I am selling myself a partner."

"I know."

"Do you want the nephew to win? He has an itch and capital. History favours him."

Nysa looked at the shelves she could now navigate without reaching blindly. Rose. Iris. Bitter almond. The small jars for apologies. Her scar pulled when she smiled.

"Then we will have to inconvenience history," she said, and picked up the broom.

Claudia took it from her before she could make industry into a speech. "Three days a week," she said. "A wage for the days, and a share of what you sell above the ordinary when you are here. Not charity. If the partnership fails, you will at least have been paid to learn which jars move in rain."

"Put it in writing."

"You have spent one morning with an accountant and become a courthouse."

"Put it in writing anyway."

Terentius, when consulted by message, returned a draft by his boy: days, wage, commission, a clause that shop work did not oblige Nysa to purchase the share and did not oblige Claudia to sell it to her if a better buyer arrived before an agreed date. It was a cold little document. Nysa signed her name with disproportionate pleasure.

That evening she made a guest list of her own. Not hosts she hoped to impress, but people whose behaviour had data behind it: Claudia, who charged her for a broken jar and therefore could be trusted about money; Terentius, who had squinted at affection until it evaporated; Caesia, who bought a jar when she would not restore a luncheon; Domitius's sister, not yet met but likely to serve good wine to enemies; Sabina, who brought cakes and gossip in equal portions; Antonia, whose help came with architecture but whose advance fees arrived as promised.

Varro's name she did not write. He occupied the margins already. Under the list she set the figures without decoration: savings about nine thousand seven hundred; price perhaps fourteen thousand five hundred; landlord before the June Kalends; lost engagements perhaps two thousand four hundred; rent due; shop wage beginning tomorrow.

She put the tablet beside her bed where compliments used to be left. In the morning it would still be there, which was more than could be said for most compliments.

The landlady knocked before she slept. This was not a social hour, but rent has never respected visiting customs.

"My cousin can take the room at the higher price," she said through the partly opened door. "He is quiet, except for a cough."

"Then let him cough at the higher price in July. I will pay the old rate to the end of June and decide by the Kalends."

"Everyone decides by the Kalends. It is a traffic problem."

Nysa paid what was due and received a mark on the tally. The landlady looked at the tablet by the bed but did not ask whether it was a love letter. People who collected rent developed an affection for documents without needing to read them.

When the door closed, Nysa added one final line in smaller writing: room until June. It was not security. It was a date by which several insecurities had agreed to meet.

She blew out the lamp and lay listening to the building resolve its own small disputes: a shutter, a couple in the room above, water in a courtyard jar. Tomorrow she would stand behind a counter and learn whether the woman with the exacting husband returned for the larger jar. It was a future made of work rather than rescue. She found she could sleep inside it.

END OF CURRENT INSTALLMENT